House of Shadows

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34705030.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Entrapta & Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Haunted House, Peril, Mystery, mer-mystery, "Sword Safety!", Sugar, Costumes/Disguises, POV Adora (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), Mutual Pining, childhood friends to ??, Alternate Universe - Modern with Magic, (kinda), double trouble can’t shapeshift and no i don’t give any explanation why, almost no trauma and angst, except fearing for their lives i guess, Inheritance, spoooooky shit, Halloween

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English

Collections:
SPOP Creative Flex, Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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by petty_labelle

Summary

"Ms. Weaver left very specific instructions in the event of her demise. She would not want the fruits of her hard work to fall into unworthy hands. And she did not believe in handouts. It was her wish for one of you to earn your inheritance. She hand-selected the 10 of you. If you can make it through one single night in this house, you will get everything."

Adora's eyes shoot across the room. She notes that pretty much everyone looks like they're just taking this in. Interest and suspicion fill most of their faces in equal measure.

"This is ridiculous," Glimmer says. "This is some kind of prank."

"I assure you, Miss, that I don't have a sense of humor," Hordak tells her.

Just one night in the creepy mansion that haunted Adora's childhood nightmares and she can be rich. Rich enough to pay for med school, help her mom out, and secure her dreams. There's only 9 other people to outlast, including her two best friends, a shady cast of characters she doesn't trust, and the girl she's been in love with her whole life. Easy.

Notes

what the fuck did i do. this is absolutely like nothing i've written before. i asked a question on twitter about whether i should next write a modern-day 'overnight stay in a haunted house' fic or post-canon ghost/soulmate. haunted house won and somehow it turned into this. just me putting everyone in peril i guess. incorporating the flex fic tags was supposed to

help bring a little levity but uh, not sure that went according to plan. so...hope you enjoy that? i don't have the stomach for causing actual physical harm to my favorite characters so you don't have to worry too much about that.

i also used raptor's amazing october flex art for added creepy inspo (https://twitter.com/Eat_thee_Rude/status/1443910764994220035).

rated t mostly for swearing. this chapter has a little bit of blood but nothing graphic ever happens to anyone.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"This is gonna be the best Halloween ever!" Bow squeals into their ears, trying to wrap his long, muscular arms around Adora and Glimmer's shoulders. The costumes are too wide – the three of them could barely fit into the backseat of the Uber and Glimmer had ordered an *XL* – so he has to settle for just lightly patting them instead.

Glimmer grumbles, awkwardly crossing her arms and scowling. When Adora had offered a group costume, both of her friends had been so excited. She'd asked them separately though, and had kinda forgot to mention that her idea involved *three* people. Adora knew Glimmer didn't love being surprised cause she usually liked to call the shots, but she'd never expected that the other girl would be so miserable once Adora revealed their Halloween ensemble. Glimmer even got to pick hers! Sorta.

"Should we ask the driver if we can play some spooky music?" Bow whispers.

Glimmer just scowls deeper.

"Excuse me?" Adora calls out towards the front seat. She hasn't been in any rideshares that have this dark partition between the driver and the back, obscuring him almost completely. It's more like a limo, which is weird but she shrugs it off, since the driver lightly grunts his attention. "Could you maybe play some Halloween music? We're trying to get into the spirit!"

She flashes him a kind smile with the hopes that he'll take pity on them. It's earlyish. Hopefully he hasn't yet had to deal with any annoying drunk people in obnoxious costumes, getting sick all over the car.

After a couple quick presses of the stereo, the silence inside of the black SUV fills with a swell of music. Bow smiles in anticipation. 20 seconds into hearing strings and a creepy high-pitched piano and what was definitely a cursed organ, Adora realizes there will be no words to this song. 30 seconds into it, Glimmer's fingers go to her temples like she's already trying to will away a headache. It's more like scary gothic church music than 'Monster Mash.'

"This is gonna be the worst fucking Halloween ever," she whines.

"No, it's gonna be great!" Adora assures her. "You've wanted to go to this party for years. We finally scored an invite. We're gonna have an amazing time!"

Now that she'd finished undergrad, Adora hadn't had much free time. To save up some money, she was working roughly 55 hours per week between doing office temp work during the day and cleaning *different* offices at night as a janitor. So she really planned on making this night out count. There wouldn't be many more opportunities; once she started med school next fall, she could basically kiss adventure and excitement goodbye for a long long time.

"I didn't realize the party was so far," Bow comments absently, eyes searching out the window. It's a little after 8pm so the sky is already dark, though the night is eerily illuminated by the huge full moon.

"Well, they need a big space. Can't find that downtown," Glimmer replies.

"But we're basically in the burbs." He cranes around Glimmer to get a better look.

That's weird. Bow's right, Adora notes, checking herself. There's more houses, more trees. Less of the skyscrapers and apartment buildings she's used to in Bright Moon.

No, this looks like the creepy woods and the tiny, gray homes in her old subdivision. It was originally named the Bright Zone and

developed to be a space for small families moving from Bright Moon. But the whole atmosphere always felt so dark and unsettling, from the drab buildings to the eeriness of the surrounding forest. So instead, everyone called it…

"The Fright Zone," Bow reads off the graffitied sign, just as they pass it.

"What?!" Adora and Glimmer scream in unison.

And indeed, there's Adora's childhood neighborhood. She hadn't been back in at least 3 years. After she moved into the city for college, Adora last returned home to help her mother pack. The family that her mom worked for as a housekeeper had been begging her to move in full-time for a good while. It was closer to Adora's campus and the house was spacious and always full of light; it took Adora bugging her constantly but her mom had been happy there ever since.

So there was no longer any reason for Adora to go back to the Fright Zone really. But she had moments where she missed hiking into the woods or seeing more stars than you usually got in the city. Or the friend she used to do all of that with.

Glimmer's continued screams break Adora out of her wandering route towards memory lane.

"Pull over right now," she yells at the driver. "You're going the wrong way!"

"Oh, shit," Bow whispers, which is super weird because Adora can count on one hand how many times she's heard him curse since she met him at freshman orientation.

"What's wrong?" Adora asks, trying to raise her voice over Glimmer's.

With a look of confused fear, he holds up their friend's sparkly lavender-colored phone, but Adora doesn't recognize anything strange in the rideshare app. Except.

“Our last request was cancelled,” she says.

Bow turns to Glimmer next. “This isn’t the car you called,” he whispers.

She begins banging her hands on the dark partition dividing them from the driver. “Who the hell are you and where are you taking us?!”

Adora forces herself not to panic. There’s probably a very reasonable explanation for all of this. While Glimmer’s response to this possible abduction is pure rage, Bow just seems very worried. On top of suddenly being out of control of the situation, the Fright Zone has a certain reputation with outsiders.

Finally, with a gloved hand, the driver reaches for his phone and presses a couple buttons. That creepy electronic ‘helper’ voice answers for him. “Where I was ordered to.”

“What the *fuck* does that mean?” Glimmer yells. She really hits the ‘fuck’ so hard that *Adora* flinches. The driver is very unimpressed though. She can't see his face because of his low hat and the divider but Adora’s pretty sure he just rolls his eyes, based on the Glimmer-esque way he tilts his head back.

Bow attempts to bargain with him, offering, “If you just let us out now, we can all write this off as a simple misunderstanding. Maybe we just got in the wrong car.”

The driver turns up the creepy organ music louder.

“I’m texting your license plate number to a bunch of friends right now,” Adora lies. “If anything happens to us, someone will find you.”

“How did you get the plate number?” Glimmer asks loudly.

The driver laughs at that. Adora probably wasn’t that convincing even before Glimmer blew her cover.

Suddenly, he slams on the brakes, jostling all of them. More typing, until the phone tells them, "Get out."

"Like hell I will," Glimmer yells back.

"Why is my phone not working?" Bow asks. He'd been poking at it for a while futilely.

"Cause this place is a fucking black hole!"

That's not actually true but Adora's too busy to argue back that reception out there has always just kinda sucked. The Fright Zone's always been a forgotten place, left behind by the big city and all its money.

She weighs their options. They can get out and try to face whatever's waiting for them. The main problem is that their costumes are so bulky, it would be hard to run or fight anyone. Their phones aren't working – Adora's has no bars either – but they could wait a bit and maybe service would come back. Hell, maybe the driver would get bored and abandon this plan if they just stayed inside and made themselves super annoying. That couldn't be too hard.

"I'm gonna start putting my fingerprints on everything," Glimmer whispers. "Good luck with your fucking kidnapping charge, Mr. Driver Guy. Bow, reach into my costume and pull out some of my hair to leave back here."

Adora keeps looking around for clues and/or possible escape plans. It's not until she glances past Glimmer that she sees exactly where they are.

They're parked at the end of a long cul-de-sac, right in front of the old Weaver house. A few superficial things have changed but it's definitely still the same creepy place it had been throughout Adora's childhood.

According to all the stories, no one knew how old the place was. It had been there for close to a century maybe, which explained

the Old World style – the terrifying pointed edges and roofs, the dark facade, the dramatic arches, the huge windows that look like yellow teeth.

When they were little kids, her best friend, Catra, used to always point out that from some angles, the house resembled an angry face. That gave Adora nightmares for weeks.

Most folks claimed the house had pre-dated everything else in the neighborhood and they were forced to build and modernize around. The fact that it sat at the end of a dead-end road, dozens of feet away from the next nearest house, seemed to confirm that. It was as if people were afraid of being in the house's atmosphere and subconsciously decided to just stay out of its way.

And now, someone was expecting Adora to go *inside.* She considered herself a pretty adventurous person but she'd never had the guts to enter Weaver's place without Catra.

Adora's pulse quickens. *Catra.* They hadn't seen each other in 4 years. Didn't even have each other's numbers since Catra was never a person you could just get ahold of. To Adora, she'd always just blown into rooms, full of energy and bad ideas, different-colored eyes lit up with mischievous excitement. Catra was hard to pinpoint, impossible to tie down.

Also, because she's the most stubborn person in the universe, Catra doesn't "believe" in phones. Or at least, she didn't when Adora left for school and their only means of communication was the occasional letter or Adora calling her house and praying that Catra was home. She never was – no one was usually – and on the rare times that Adora was able to get ahold of Catra's mom, it felt silly leaving messages that she was sure would never be returned. After Adora's mom moved away, she'd just kinda resigned herself to the fact that she'd maybe never see Catra again. Not unless Catra wanted that too.

“There’s more cars,” Bow points out. Adora follows his line of vision to the windshield and sees that there’s a couple sedans parked on the street in front of them. And a motorcycle. It’s old and beat-up, with fading black fenders and a terribly designed red gas tank where Adora had tried to spray flames on it and failed miserably.

Catra laughed at her at the time but didn’t complain, even though she’d spent all the money she had saved over the previous two summers and now it was ruined. Turns out Adora didn’t really know how to draw. Or pick out paint. Or explain to Catra that she couldn’t make the silly cliched image they’d dreamed up together into a reality. As soon as it dried, Catra took Adora for a ride anyway, zooming too fast through the roads as the blonde held on tight and cheered the whole time.

The flames are mostly gone now, just some smeared hints of orange remaining.

Adora jumps out of the truck without thinking.

Glimmer immediately begins to panic. “Where are you going?!”

‘Catra’s here’ is on the tip of Adora’s tongue. Bow’s never met Adora’s first friend, though. Glimmer *has* , but it was a complete disaster, the two of them clashing anytime they were in the same room. Plus it feels a little silly to rush towards danger just because Catra *might* be inside.

It’s been such a long time since they’ve seen each other, Adora reminds herself. She has to at least try.

“I’m just gonna check it out really quickly. Maybe we can get some answers.”

She rushes off as fast as this heavy costume will allow, storming up the long gravelly walkway towards the tall, swooping iron gates.

The lights are on in one of the front rooms on the first floor.

What the hell could possibly get Catra to return to Weaver's place? For that matter, why had Adora and her friends been brought there too?

The wind changes as soon as she crosses the threshold of the gates and Adora has to pause to get used to it. That always used to happen – Catra claimed it was cause the place was cursed. Outside the gates, it didn't matter if the sun was shining bright and there wasn't even a light breeze; inside, the temperature would consistently drop, fog rolling in and keeping you from being able to see more than a couple of feet in front of your face.

Adora takes a deep breath and hopes that Bow follows her and brings their extra change of clothes. He'd insisted on it just in case they got tired of the costumes and Adora was starting to appreciate that. This ridiculous outfit wasn't exactly how she wanted to re-introduce herself – cooler and more grown-up now – to someone who was once the most beautiful girl she'd ever met.

She continues on up the darkening path. The house is still a looming giant but much less tall than it had appeared when she was a kid. Back then, Adora remembers it trailing up to the sky.

Her mom had always warned her to stay away from the Weaver place. Catra, of course, never listened to that. She swore that end of the street was the best place for batting practice, since it had so much free space. They'd been playing around one day when Catra hit an absolute dinger. She'd smirked and flexed and begun to skip towards invisible bases when they heard the crash. Catra had wanted to run. Adora had been undecided about that – her mother would have been so ashamed if some elderly sweet woman came by and told her that Adora and Catra had been seen running away from her house – and that hesitation cost them just enough time that a sudden figure caught up with them.

She was all shadows at first, Adora swears. Like, it genuinely felt as if the shadows on the sidewalk took human form and descended on the two kids. That's just a silly trick of the mind though, remembering Weaver as much scarier than she was. She

was tall and thin as a rail, dressed in a rich red velvet material that completely encased her. They were both terrified as she explained how they were disrespectful children who needed to be taught a lesson. Catra sneered and fought back but once Weaver threatened to tell their parents, they both agreed to work off the cost of the window.

Weeks after school were spent *inside* the creepy mansion. The work was...mysterious. Bizarre, really. Beakers of secret colorful concoctions needed to be bottled and stacked away. Each day, they filled cases and cases of tiny glass jars, Weaver bearing down on them the entire time, eyes narrowed in silent judgment.

Catra hated it. She hated the chill in the house, the fire in Weaver's tone. The meticulousness and monotony of the work. Of course, she was good at it. Adora was sure that Catra never actually bothered trying anything she thought she might not excel at. When late summer turned to mid-fall, Catra became convinced that they'd more than worked off the cost of the window. Weaver promised cash if they'd return. And so they went back, spending years dropping in and doing grunt work whenever they needed the money. Adora's hands weren't as deft and precise as Catra's but she needed the cash more – with her thick Eternian accent, her mother often struggled to find or keep work due to people's shitty attitudes. Adora was happy to help out a bit.

Things got too weird when Catra actually learned how to make the strange creations that Weaver brewed up in her secret lab. Well, it was more like a secret kitchen in the basement than an actual laboratory. They were strictly banned from entering. Weaver would leave materials in the hall and strict instructions.

Adora never wanted to go down anyway – there were cobwebs and probably mice and it always smelled strongly of things that living beings shouldn't be around for long periods.

But Catra had insisted they needed to investigate and snuck in a few times while Weaver was out. They'd been sloppy and gotten caught that time though. Instead of apologizing, Catra defiantly

told Weaver she wanted a promotion. Like it was an actual job and not illegal child labor in some strange woman's witchy cellar.

Maybe 'witchy' isn't the right word. Weaver was eccentric, old, and rich, and no one knew really anything about her, including where she'd gotten her money from or when she'd ended up with the house. Catra had always joked that she *had* to be a witch since there was no other way to explain the way chills went up their spines in her presence. Adora never believed her. Or it was just easier not to think about it when they were spending so much time there. Her mom appreciated the extra money. Best not to ask questions and mess that up. Not even *Catra* seemed to know exactly *what* it was she was so expertly brewing.

When Adora and Catra neared college-age, Weaver took on more kid helpers. "Apprentices," she'd called them and Adora had no idea where she'd found them or what their parents thought they were up to. Except Glimmer, who was only a year younger and showed up one day. Weaver had been happy to have her, praising the girl for defying her mother and seeking out someone she could *truly* learn from. Adora stayed on a couple more weeks but after a new apprentice, Lonnie, started, there was less need for her and therefore, less cash.

Catra left with her and Adora hadn't been back since.

"Oh my Gods!" Glimmer yells, breaking Adora out of her thoughts. She's only been here two minutes and already she's been possessed by the spirits of the past. "Why is this fog so fucking thick?!"

With a huff, Glimmer stops next to Adora. Bow comes up soon, both of them sweating from trying to rush in their costumes.

"The driver took off," he explains. "But I got our bag. Still no reception though." Bow looks from Adora to the house before frowning.

Adora reads the question on his face. “I’m going inside. I don’t know what’s going on but I used to come to this place all the time. I don’t think it’s a coincidence that the car brought us here. But I’d understand it if you two want to wait outside.”

“Out here?!? No, I’m going too. This place doesn’t scare me anymore,” Glimmer declares. Her eyes don’t seem as sure as her tone.

With a firm nod, Bow joins them as they begin towards the porch.

He’s the one who knocks. Glimmer and Adora both move to open the door and storm in to get some answers. Bow reminds them to be polite and ask for permission to enter.

A large scorpion in a three-piece black suit with a white starched shirt nearly tears the door off getting it open. She’s a few inches taller than Bow and almost as broad as the doorframe, completely ripped. But she’s bouncing on her tiptoes like an excited kid.

“Oh, I just love trick or treaters!” she squeals. Then she begins explaining, much too quickly, “Sorry it took me so long to get the door. I was cooking a roast-” She distractedly waves around a meat thermometer in her hand “And I rushed over as soon as I could. Your costumes are so funny! I like it! Now, I do *not* have any candy for you unfortunately. The lady of the house never let me put it out because she thought kids didn’t deserve anything for free and usually trick or treaters don’t even stop by here. Ya know, on account of it being so creepy and dark. Usually people just want to play pranks. Say!” She leans closer and narrows her eyes at them, particularly focusing on Adora. “You’re not pranking us, right?”

She pauses to take a breath for the first time in what feels like 5 minutes. Adora’s trying to catch up to her when she hears something that makes her heart get trapped in her throat.

“Relax, Scorp. They're invited.”

Even after a few years, Adora immediately recognises Catra's raspy voice, still familiar yet a little more mature. Adora moves to push the scorpion woman out of the way but she's an unmovable boulder.

"Hey, watch it, buddy," she says, waving the thermometer in Adora's face.

"Cool it, Scorpia. That's Adora," Catra adds.

That's all it takes for this 'Scorpia' to step aside, looking appropriately shamed. Scorpia would have been in for a hell of a fight...if Adora was dressed more properly for it. She'd taken some self-defense classes down at the Y and her instructor, Netossa, said she was becoming a real formidable force. Against a purse snatcher, Netossa usually added, but that's not important.

Adora rushes inside. Vaguely she hears Scorpia offering to take Bow and Glimmer's non-existent coats and politely greeting them. Adora's attention is completely occupied.

She spots Catra in the sitting room, leaning against the doorway. All around her – the foyer, that ancient and dusty formal front room – everything is exactly the same. Dark mahogany, wood paneling on the walls, high archways, and even higher ceilings. The whole place, the creepy paintings of people who look like they're posing under threat of personal harm, the kraken-like chandelier, the rose-colored sconces, the intricate red and gold rugs, the heavy black curtains, is still as dreary as ever.

Catra, on the other hand, *has* changed quite a bit. She's a little taller, for starters, and Adora estimates they might be only a couple inches apart in height for the first time since she hit a growth spurt during 6th grade and felt like she was towering over the other girl. Catra's face is different too, more angular around the cheeks and chin. Her dark, wild, curly mane is even more untamed, flowing down past her shoulder blades. There's a swatch of hair buzzed off right above both of her ears, just about the length and width of four fingers, and that plus the dark denim

jacket, torn black leggings, and sleeveless black t-shirt she's got on, just manage to make Catra look infinitely more badass.

Yeah. Definitely *still* the most beautiful person Adora's ever met.

"Seen a ghost?" Catra asks. She smirks, her lips quirking up on the right side until Adora can see one of her fangs. Behind her, her tail weaves unsurely in the air, giving her true feelings away.

The blonde rushes over as quickly as her bulky attire will allow.

"You godsdamn jerk!" Adora screams, punching her in the shoulder. She's not for real angry, mostly just sad and annoyed. Roughhousing was always their language though.

"What?!" Catra screeches, tail fluffing out. Her voice breaks, reminding Adora of when it first began to awkwardly drop and Catra would call the school pretending to be her mom to keep them out of trouble.

"You never called me back! You disappeared on me!"

Catra's face contorts into a frown. But she quickly gives Adora a small smile.

"I'm sorry. I can't take you serious like this," she explains, waving at the costume.

"Catra!"

"Okay, I'm actually sorry." Her ears lower in shame. "You seemed so busy in the city and with school." For a moment, her eyes flicker over to Bow and Glimmer and then back to Adora. "I didn't want to bother you."

"You're never a bother," Adora tells her sincerely. "I missed you."

Catra gives her another small smile. "Yeah? Come here," she says and her voice sounds nervous, like it did when Catra would sleep

over and get freaked out at the unfamiliar noises in Adora’s house at night, though she'd never cop to it.

Much like then, Adora reaches out and pulls Catra into her arms. She fits differently now; her head lands in Adora’s neck instead of in her chest. Or rather, it would if not for this godsdamn costume. She can just *barely* feel thin strong arms struggling to wrap around her and Catra’s warmth against her body.

Adora has to settle for burying her face in Catra’s hair. She still smells like palo santo and cocoa. It's a scent that coated Adora’s pillows as a kid when sleepovers were common between them. On her favorite hoodie in middle school since Catra used to steal it and wear it all day. On her fingertips just after she left town, the two of them holding each other close in an attempt to convince themselves that nothing would have to change.

This – *Catra* – this is home. The only one Adora's ever really known. Her mother's house in the Fright Zone always felt temporary; dorms and even her apartment with Bow and Glimmer in Bright Moon just feel like a place to keep her stuff for a short while. Here, though? This is where she belongs. Where her internal compass points back towards.

After a long moment, Adora sighs. It’s met with a quiet purr from deep within Catra’s throat and Adora once again wishes she wasn't in so many awkward layers, just so she could feel that rumbling close to her skin. It's a sound she's known most of her life, as familiar to her as her own breathing.

A throat awkwardly clears nearby. Adora doesn't care; this is her moment with her best friend and whoever that is can wait their turn.

Adora slowly opens her eyes to see Scorpia hovering over Catra’s shoulder, face angry and puzzled but trying to hide it. Good luck breaking this up, Adora thinks. She’s not letting go unless Catra does. She can wait here all night.

“That’s a mighty long hug there,” Scorpia observes with a frown. “Maybe you should give Catra some space and go have a seat with the other guests.”

She visually follows where Scorpia’s claw is pointing. Over Catra’s shoulder, Adora sees five additional people hanging around the sitting room, most of them giving her and Catra odd looks. Adora recognizes Lonnie frowning at her in her form-fitting black sweater, gray jeans, and heavy boots; her brown locs have grown out a lot, with the sides and back now shaved, and her skin has cleared up. The others are strangers though: a thin, light green lizard person seated on the couch with their long legs crossed, dressed in a black leather jumpsuit and stiletto boots; an impish blonde guy waiting nervously in the corner, in a suit that matches Scorpia; a bored looking dark-skinned, teal-haired woman in all black – leather jacket, turtleneck, and tights – leaned against the bar and scowling; and climbing the ceiling-high bookshelves built into the wall is a woman with overalls and knee-length purple pigtails.

They’re probably fine people but Adora’s perfect where she is.

Catra moves her head to mumble, “I don’t need your help. Thanks though.”

“As ⅓ of the Super Pal Trio, I have to argue. You wouldn’t want to…” Scorpia’s eyes flit nervously to Adora. “Get your hopes up again.”

Catra pulls back to growl at her. Adora can appreciate the protectiveness but she kinda has a few years of hugs to catch up on.

Glimmer must have just noticed the extra people as well because she asks, “What's going on here?”

“The old lady passed away,” Lonnie answers casually. Her voice is completely devoid of emotion.

That breaks through the Catra-induced euphoria. Weaver's dead? And they're in her home? Forced to come there?

She has to place a hand on Catra's shoulder to steady herself, pulling her friend's attention back to her.

“You okay?” Catra asks.

Adora nods. “Sorry. It's weird. Never thought she was…”

“Mortal?” Catra finishes, deadpan.

“Vulnerable, maybe?” Catra's face shifts to something almost morose and Adora reaches for her again. “How-?”

“Catra, as your best friend, I'm gonna have to insist on a sidebar here for a quick check in,” Scorpia says. She seems to notice the meat thermometer in her hand for the first time and reaches to put it down on a nearby side table, flat on its face with the pointy side up.

Adora doesn't really want to spend more time in this house but Catra and a roast were a tempting combo. Looks like dinner will probably be ruined though.

Something about this all strikes her right in the temple.

“Wait. The butler's your best friend?”

Bow gasps, “Adora!”, clutching at non-existent pearls.

“I didn't mean it like a snob! I just meant – you never wanted to come here. And now you're hanging here often enough that you have friends?”

All of Scorpia's sweet, ‘aw shucks’ energy is gone in an instant.

She steps closer to Adora. “Look, buddy. I don't know what your deal is but I do not like you. Not one bit.”

“Take it down a notch, Scorpia,” Catra says but her voice sounds pretty amused. She's enjoying watching Adora squirm a little. “Adora didn't mean anything by it. You're acting weird today.”

Catra puts her hands on the sides of Adora's costume, where her hips would be, and tilts them both away from prying eyes. Bow correctly reads the situation and tries to lead Glimmer into the sitting room. She instead joins Scorpia in hovering close by.

“So…” Adora has lots of things she’d like to say but Scorpia’s dancing in the corner of her vision and it’s very distracting. “Weaver’s gone, huh?”

She hopes the real question can be read in there – what the hell are we doing here and how'd they trick you into this?

“Yeah,” Catra says, looking grim. “She bit it. Bought the farm. All the other weird metaphors for saying the old girl’s good and dead.”

She pauses to take a good look at Adora, Glimmer, and Bow, before adding. “I mean, none of us were exactly broken up about it but we weren’t throwing a fucking party.” With a teasing glint in her eye, Catra looks at the dumb costume and says, “That’s in poor taste, Adora.”

The blonde's dismissive eye roll is cut short by Catra extending the claws on her right hand. Without looking away, Catra trails one long black nail down the center of Adora's torso.

“I can't believe you fell for the oldest trick in the book. ‘Come to this mysterious place looking like a complete fool?’ I thought I taught you better than that.”

“First,” Adora says, raising her own hand to point. She has to hide the grin that’s threatening to form; she always did enjoy Catra's teasing maybe a little too much. “We were kidnapped, not tricked. Someone hacked Glimmer's rideshare app to get us here or something.”

“Kidnapping *is* the oldest trick in the book.”

“And we were going to an actual party.”

“Yeah? What's it called?” Catra leans forward in a challenge.

“Glimmer knows!” Adora deflects.

Catra doesn't even bother acknowledging that she can just turn and ask. “And third?”

“Third! ...Why are you here?”

Catra shrugs, “The universal motive. Money.”

“Money?” Adora repeats. She's even more confused than before and that's saying a lot cause, you know, abduction and all. “You're not gonna finally loot the place, are you?”

“And try to balance these 30-foot antique rugs on my bike? Nah, but I always did love the way you think.”

Adora hopes that the low lights in the house can help hide the way her cheeks heat up just from hearing Catra say she loves anything about Adora.

“Then what's your plan?” she tries to whisper.

“Hello!” a deep, rich voice booms suddenly next to them. Like right next to them, basically teleporting into the doorframe across from Catra.

Everyone – all five of them in the foyer and most of the people in the sitting room except that lizard, Adora notices – startles.

Standing proudly there is an unnaturally pale man, tall and skinny and shoulders pushed back in a show of perfect posture. He's sporting a dark charcoal suit, navy blue shirt that matches his short slicked down hair, and a blood red pocket square the same color as his eyes.

He doesn't seem at all concerned that he just almost gave everyone a heart attack. “It seems I entered at just the right moment.”

“Fucking stars, Hordak,” Catra murmurs. “Are you trying to kill us?”

“Would save us all some time...” he mutters back quietly.

Catra definitely hears that, her face blanching.

He continues on, “If you wouldn't mind all joining me in the sit-” Mid-sentence, he pauses to look over Bow, Glimmer, and Adora. “I can't believe that worked.”

Catra snorts loudly but that's lost under Glimmer screaming, “Someone better tell me what the fuck is happening here!”

“Yeah, Hordak was literally just offering to do that if you'd stop whining and listen,” Catra points out.

Thankfully, Scorpia goes into full butler mode to guide everyone into the sitting room. Glimmer and Bow awkwardly attempt to half-slide onto one of the low, clunky emerald velvet couches. Adora figures it's easiest to stand so she leans onto the bar where Catra's joined the dark-skinned girl in getting into Weaver's whiskey collection.

Scorpia continues to wait by the door while Hordak moves to the mantle above the fireplace, just a few feet to the left of her.

“Some of you may not be familiar with me,” he begins. “I am Hordak, Ms. Weaver's... representative.”

Catra shoots Adora a look over her highball glass. It's hard to read though, and for the first time, Adora realizes that they've probably lost a lot of their old cues.

“Ms. Weaver left very specific instructions in the event of her demise. She would not want the fruits of her hard work to fall into

unworthy hands. And she did not believe in handouts. It was her wish for one of you to *earn* your inheritance. She hand-selected the 10 of you along with methods that could reliably get you here."

"What worked for everyone else?" Bow asks.

"Darling, the email saying I could be filthy fucking rich," the lizard answers and everyone else pretty much nods or mumbles their agreement.

Adora had not received that. Or possibly, her email read the words "filthy" and "fucking" and sent it to spam.

Hordak continues, "If you can make it through one single night in this house, you will get everything. If more than one of you is lucky enough to do so, you will split the money, the property, and so on, evenly."

Adora's eyes shoot across the room. She notes that pretty much everyone looks like they're just taking this in. Interest and suspicion fill most of their faces in equal measure. But not Catra. She's already thinking something up, Adora's sure of it, eyes narrowed and free hand tapping anxiously against the bar. Catra could cook up a scheme in record-time, always so quick on her feet.

The possibilities are...a little overwhelming. Even 10% of what Weaver had is more than anyone in Adora's family has ever even *imagined* making. But more than 10%, just for maybe scaring a few strangers off? If they were worthy, like Hordak said, they'd be able to take a little friendly competition.

"This is ridiculous," Glimmer says. "This is some kind of prank."

"I assure you, Miss, that I don't have a sense of humor," Hordak tells her.

"Now, that's true," Lonnie says with a dry laugh.

“Why us?” Bow asks. “Why did she pick us specifically?”

“I'll leave you all to parse that out. Though I will reveal...” He pauses and then his voice turns much less serious, “One of you is only here to make it a round number.”

Not subtly at all, the girl at the bar and the lizard both point at the blonde in the corner.

“Hey!” he argues, offended. “I carried out all of her grunt work for *years!* If anyone deserves some kind of reward, it's me.”

“A month ago, I heard her call you Cal,” Catra comments. “So obviously you were real close.”

The purple-haired person finally jumps down from the most recent bookcase that she'd been inspecting.

“Hordak, I assume our prior relationship will have no impact on my chances of winning,” she says.

“Hordark and Entrapta are exes,” Catra loudly whispers so the whole room can hear her. “It's messy.”

“You're one to talk, Kitten,” the lizard drawls out, smiling. Their voice is...slick, almost? It makes Adora feel wary immediately.

Catra cuts her eyes towards them in a way that’s absolutely deadly.

“About how much money would it be? Roughly?” Adora asks.

“From what I’ve gathered, Weaver had amassed quite a fortune over the years,” Entrapta answers. “Most of which the government probably is not aware of. No taxes. No strings.”

“Well, a *few* strings,” Bow replies, motioning around them.

Catra’s drinking buddy knocks back the rest of her cocktail. “Look. I deserve this money. I’m not playing this little game. I know

where the old bag kept her cash. I'll just take what's mine and be on my way."

Hordak assures her, "Mermista, there's much more if you stay and win the inheritance."

She seems to be weighing that option when Hordak clears his throat. His red eyes look bored.

"Anyway, if you all choose to remain and participate, whoever is in this room at 8:00 am sharp when I return will be the victor. I trust that you'll all keep each other honest and ensure that no one leaves and returns."

"Wait – an 8 am wake up call?!" Catra whines.

"Call?" Hordark huffs. "Does this look like a bed and breakfast to you?"

And then he just leaves without another word. He turns sharply on his heel and disappears around the corner, in the direction of the front door.

For a long moment, they sit there in tense silence. Adora's still struggling to catch up on how her night went from harmless Halloween fun to trapped in this house. Weaver attracted shady characters so it's only natural to have a heavy dose of suspicion about the company she's in right now.

If this isn't a joke, if this is a real chance at a sizable reward, she'd be a fool to pass on it. Med school wasn't exactly cheap, especially if she wanted to go to Bright Moon U. Overnight in this place wouldn't be too bad. She never stayed far past sunset as a kid but Adora's an adult now. She works out. She has some decent survival skills. Bow's great at planning, Glimmer's completely fearless, and Catra always knew how to figure out the mansion's secrets. Maybe if they team up, they can split the money together.

“Are you dumbasses actually considering this?” Mermista asks in a mocking tone. A part of Adora thinks this is her plan for winning, making everyone feel silly so they’ll forfeit and go home. “Hordak could have made this whole thing up!”

“For what purpose?” Entrapta asks.

“I don’t know about the rest of you but I’ve certainly never done anything to get on Hordak’s bad side,” the lizard says. “If there’s money to be made, I’m game. The loss of our mutual employer has been a bit of a jolt to my bank account.”

“Not all of us worked for Weaver,” Glimmer argues.

“Yeah, sausage person – I don’t recall ever seeing you around,” they reply.

It takes Adora a second to realize they’re speaking to her. Well, really, it takes Catra *laughing* for her to understand what’s happening.

“I’m a hot dog,” Adora mutters. Obviously. The heavy brown cotton weiner covers from her head down to her knees, wrapped in a fake bun, with only her arms and legs out and visible. Glimmer and Bow are her cute little squeeze bottles of ketchup and mustard, respectively, with thick round suits that end at their shins and large pointy hats on their heads.

It was a pretty clever costume, so it’s fine that this person didn’t get it.

“Ooh, can we do a quick check-in question?” Scorpia asks. “Those are the best! Name, what brought you here, and, uh...what’s your favorite hot dog topping? Ya know, just so we can get to know each other better.”

“Absolutely not,” the lizard replies. “I’m Double Trouble or DT. I *had* been Weaver’s apprentice until two weeks ago when Scorpia told me the old biddy had kicked the bucket. And then a couple

days ago, Hordak emailed me out of the blue and told me he had a lucrative opportunity for me."

They all say more or less the same thing and Adora's able to put names to the remaining faces. Mermista, the barfly, was Weaver's right-hand. Kyle, the squirrelly blonde, described a role that sounds like a glorified errand boy. Entrapta, who supported home security, which seems odd cause there's not a single thing that looks different or upgraded that Adora can see. Lonnie had remained on in Adora's previous role. Scorpia was still living in the house until given further orders. By *who* , she doesn't say.

"Well, I was an apprentice," Glimmer answers. "For only about a summer. That's where I met Adora. Bow's just our friend. I guess Hordak didn't think we'd fall for the money trick so he emailed us some bullshit party invite instead."

"So you don't always go around dressed up as a hot dog and a couple of condiments?" Lonnie jokes. "And the three of y'all aren't together?" The way she drops her voice at the last word, she definitely means it as 'more than friends,' which is a silly thought.

Glimmer blushes as red as her ketchup bottle costume. "No. We are *not."*

"What exactly was Weaver's business?" Bow asks.

"My dear, some things are better left unknown," DT answers vaguely.

Slowly, they all turn to Catra, the only one who hasn't shared yet. Adora has to take a deep breath to push down how urgently she wants to hear every single thing that she's missed since she left for school.

"You all know me. Except for Arrow," is all she says.

"Come on, kitty," Mermista taunts. Adora can feel herself narrow her eyes at the nickname. "You were closest to Weaver. Is this shit for real?"

“Closest to Weaver?” Adora repeats. The idea would have been laughable before. But there’s a grimace on Catra’s face now. “Wait. What's she talking about?”

“Look, it was stupid but I came crawling back a few months after you moved,” she says quietly, only for Adora. “I even tried working a few other places but you know how shitty the options are around here. The pay got a lot better once I helped her hone some recipes, though *of course*, she’d never give me any credit.”

Adora’s pretty sure all the color drains from her face. Catra was in way deeper than she’d thought.

“It wasn’t bad,” Catra adds quickly. “She even lightened up a bit. I mean, we stopped being at each other’s throats all the time. Plus, I learned that I actually *like* all this chemistry bullshit. I made enough to put myself through the community college. I was gonna apply to a teaching fellows program when I saved up more cash. Come back here and teach high school chem.”

As she explains this, Adora watches her get more and more nervous, like she’s worried about being judged. But this is all amazing. Catra, who never wanted to make a single realistic plan, has mapped out where she’s going. And she wants to help people!

Adora tries to voice that but all that comes out when she opens her mouth is a weird, high-pitched giggle.

“The idea of me molding young minds is that funny to you?”

“No. I’m just so...proud of you.”

Catra has to lower her head to hide her growing smile. In the background, Adora can hear DT humming.

“I say we pick teams!” Scorpia suddenly announces. “Strength in numbers and all that. I’ll take Catra and Entrapta.”

She comes over to drag Catra away before Adora can open her mouth to protest.

"I'll take Adora and Bow," Glimmer says just as suddenly.

"Hold on," Adora tries but she's cut off by Mermista.

"I'm gonna sit here and drink until sunrise. If any of you think you're getting rid of me, think again."

"Don't be so fucking paranoid, Merm," Lonnie tells her.

"Lonnie, you can join us if you'd like," Scorpia offers.

Kyle looks at the two small groups that have formed and then at Double Trouble.

"Hard pass," DT says to him. "If no one minds, I'll just...float around."

"You mean, you'll switch teams back and forth whenever it benefits you most," Catra guesses.

DT meets her eyes. "I'm sure you'll be doing the same, Kitten."

"I'm not certain any of this will be necessary," Entrapta comments, seeming to ignore the way the other two are edging towards a stand-off. "This house is surprisingly safe and I've never seen evidence of the...supernatural elements that everyone else whispers about. If we each choose a room and retire to it, I'm sure everything will be fine."

Almost as if the universe itself had timed it for the perfect moment to scare her out of her skin, Adora hears a loud crash towards the back of the house. A harsh crack, similar to the breaking of glass.

She startles, reaching to place a hand on the bar. Instead it's grabbed by Catra whose eyes are wide and her tail is fluffed out. The others – Glimmer, Scorpia, Bow, and Kyle really – seem

genuinely concerned. DT, Lonnie, and Mermista don't react but Adora can't tell if they're just being stubborn or are actually this cool under pressure.

"What was that?" Bow asks.

"It sounded like someone broke a window," Kyle says, with a tremble in his voice. "Maybe they're trying to get inside. What if this is all a trap to kill us all?"

"I don't think anyone would go through that much trouble for you," DT tells him, snickering.

"I'm gonna go check it out," Adora suggests. "Just in case."

"Not alone!" Glimmer argues.

"You three go and the rest of us can wait here," Scorpia offers.

"I'm with this dummy," Catra says tugging on their joined hands. Adora had forgotten about that. Amidst the panic, she hadn't had time to notice how Catra's smaller, slightly rough hands still felt perfect in hers.

Catra never was one for much negotiation. As soon as she states her intent, she's dragging Adora out of the room and towards the sound, leaving everyone else to scamper out behind them.

"If this was a horror movie, you'd all be dead now," Mermista calls out to them from the sitting room.

There's nothing amiss in the foyer. Catra leads the group further into the house and Adora feels the temperature slowly drop. That used to always bother her – how the mansion had 'cold spots', rooms that were chillier for no apparent reason.

As they move, they're faced with three options, head towards the long halls on either the right or the left or the narrow passageway that leads straight to the kitchen.

“Where do you think the sound came from?” Adora asks since Catra’s hearing is much better.

“This way,” she answers and begins towards the right. There should be nothing down here except the dining room with an extra route to the kitchen and a bathroom.

Behind her, Adora feels a hand on her back and her spine goes stick straight. She jumps and nearly lets out a shout, heart pounding in her chest.

“Sorry,” Bow whispers. “Just wanted to stay close.”

It’s hard to see in this costume so Adora has to turn her full body around to take a look at him. She nearly jumps again when she catches sight of their full crew, sans Mermista, huddled together, all creeped out and hiding behind her and Catra.

Adora scoffs at being used as a human shield.

The floor begins to squeak as she turns back to continue. It creaks under their weight but it’s the only sound she can hear besides quiet breathing nearby. Kyle’s probably hyperventilating.

They creep into the dark dining room. There’s a bit of moonlight slipping through the half-closed dark sapphire curtains. Adora doesn’t bother with the light. She knows Catra will adjust and she wouldn’t want to alert a potential threat to their presence. The other sets of footsteps stop in the hall and Adora doesn’t turn back to confirm that everyone else has paused at the entryway to possibly watch her and Catra fight an intruder. It wouldn't be that different than when they’d beat up that person trying to steal Adora’s bicycle out of the front yard as two 13-year-olds.

The room is empty as far as Adora can tell. There’s no one in the 12 or so large wooden elaborately-carved chairs seated around the matching table in the center. The huge lamp hanging overhead casts bizarre shadows across the wall, the moonlight hitting it so that that fringey shade looks like long, thin fingers.

With barely a shared look, Catra and Adora nod towards the table and both drop to their knees quickly to peek under it. Satisfied to find nothing, Catra gives a short tug on Adora's hand before motioning with her chin towards the closest set of curtains.

Catra insists on kicking them all, which doesn't seem like the safest idea to Adora. All someone has to do is reach out and grab her leg and then she's done. They move together, until they're finished checking behind each one.

Adora even investigates the doors that lead to the patio on the side of the house but they're locked. No broken windows. No signs of anything at all.

The kitchen doesn't turn up much either. Adora has to duck to not be bumped on the head by all the copper pots and cast iron skillets hanging over the center island. She wonders how Scorpia moves around, being as tall as she is. They inspect the pantry and even the old iron stove but all they find is a burnt, dry roast.

"Other side of the house?" Adora asks. As soon as Catra nods, they all take off that way.

There's nothing suspicious in the passageway. Nothing out of place in the huge library, full of dusty tomes that no one ever touched. Or in the small reading nook attached to it.

Maybe they all made it up?

They trek back towards the sitting room, the atmosphere growing just a little calmer.

"Could we have missed something?" Bow asks.

"This house is *full* of secret hidden spots," Entrapta tells him. "These old homes always had some place for people to keep their valuables. I've never known why this particular house had *so many*, but none of them seem to have a window. At least, none I've discovered so far."

“Do you have cameras or anything set up?” Glimmer questions.

She shakes her head. “Weaver wasn’t interested. Most of the house’s security system is in the gate.”

“And in whatever spirits protect this place,” Lonnie adds.

DT scoffs. “You think a ghost knocked a vase over? And then had time to clean it up and hide it from us?”

“We should split up and check the crawlspaces and stuff,” Kyle suggests.

“That’s a great idea. Cause you’re the only one who fits,” Catra replies.

“Entrapta’s suggestion to just wait in a bedroom until tomorrow morning is starting to sound like the best option,” Scorpia says. “I’ll set up a room for each team so folks can stay together.”

Adora feels Catra’s grip on her hand tighten, once again reminding her that they’re still intertwined.

Catra takes a quiet deep breath before she says, “I don’t think we have anything to worry about. The scariest thing about this house is already dead. We’ll be fine.”

As the leader, Catra’s the first to cross back into the sitting room and see. It takes Adora a brief moment to understand why her steps stutter. She watches Catra’s eyes go wide before her face clouds over with doubt and then a deep lack of amusement.

Adora herself doesn’t slow down until she follows Catra’s line of sight. On the floor next to the bar, in the space Mermista had occupied before, is a thick, dark red pool of liquid. *Blood.*

At first, Adora thinks maybe the whiskey caught up to her and Mermista cut her hand or something. Who knows how long she’d been there and drinking?

But then she notices the leather jacket on the floor, also covered in blood. And discarded next to it is Scorpia’s meat thermometer, gory and broken, the glass shattered.

Adora slows to a full stop, causing the group following closely behind her to bump clumsily into her and Catra. There’s a few people asking questions but Adora can’t hear them. It’s almost like she has water in her ears or something.

The others pour out of the doorway, pushing her and Catra to the side.

“Oh,” she can just barely hear Lonnie whispering. “We’re fucked.”

Chapter End Notes

this chapter has a small nod to one of my all-time favorite moments i've ever read in a fic. it taught me everything i ever need to know about baseball.

posting this every other day from now til halloween.

i'm writing fluff after this. that's the only way the healing can begin.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> thank you so much to everyone who read the first chapter! replying to comments was tough cause i didn't want to give spoilers but i'm also so bad at keeping my damn mouth shut. i've ruined so many tv shows for people.
>
> may i interest you in some catra pov? she's super cool and calculating on the outside but surprise! a disaster inside.
>
> there's a bit of spicy thoughts so warning for that. this is still rated t but it's a strong t.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista thinks she's *sooo* fucking funny.

First, she refused to answer any of Catra's questions about what the hell Hordak was up to, even though if anyone could figure it out, it would be Mermista. Then she showed up early – which she absolutely never does – just to drink all of Weaver's good booze before Catra could get her hands on it. *And then*, she pulls a stupid prank and fakes her own kidnapping. She probably had that idiot boyfriend of hers, Sea Hawk, create a distraction and she's gonna jump out in a few minutes and scare the shit out of everyone.

Kyle will definitely faint. Maybe it'll be worth it just to see that. Without Weaver, he's been wandering around the house like he owns it, being all weird. Probably trying to steal all the shit Catra's had her eyes on for years.

"Mermista?!" he yells, voice shaky with fear.

"Your little stunt isn't going to work," DT calls out to her. "We know no one would be dumb enough to actually attack you. Not

after that video went viral of you dragging that trucker out of his rig and making him cry because he catcalled you."

Glimmer perks up. "Holy shit, was that her? She's my hero."

Catra snorts at that.

Ever since Mermista showed up at Weaver's place a couple years ago offering some shady-ass connections to whatever shady-ass shit the old broad was wrapped up in, she's been nothing but trouble. The kind of trouble Catra likes, mind you, but trouble nonetheless. She drives a different car every couple of weeks. She always makes other people answer her phone. She once went to dinner with Catra, took her through the front door, and then pushed her right out the back, claiming that they couldn't stay there for unspecified reasons. They ended up eating tacos in her car under the streetlights of a random corner while Mermista had a 90-minute screeching match with Sea Hawk. On speakerphone.

So yeah, it makes sense that Sparkles would be into that energy. She's nothing but trouble herself. Her whole damn family's got some kind of special power that makes Catra's hackles raise. That giant winged mother of hers dropped in one time to yell at Weaver about influencing her kid and whatever energy she gave off had Catra's fur standing up for hours. Sparkles herself radiates that same hocus pocus nonsense, though their recently-deceased boss claimed that Glitter's ties to her emotions – her temper, her rawness – always blocked her ability to tap into her power. That checks out honestly. Kinda hard to focus your gifts if you're too busy carrying a boulder-sized chip on your shoulder about being in your successful family's shadow *and* an endless supply of rage.

Spending 12 hours overnight with these people is bad enough without Mermista trying to add Scooby Doo-level hijinks to it.

"It's just a joke," Catra announces. "She's gonna pop out from behind a curtain and yell 'boo' any second now."

“What if someone broke in and circled back behind us to attack Mermista?” Kyle asks.

“And with the meat thermometer?” Scorpia says. Catra notices she has tears in her eyes. “Mermista was a pescatarian!”

“It's kinda a lot of blood,” Adora whispers. Her face is crinkled up in concern, brow furrowed, nose scrunched.

If Mermista's ruining the first time Catra's seen Adora in 4 years, she better actually *be dead.*

With a silent sigh, Catra reluctantly lets go of Adora’s hand. She has to ignore the familiarity of it, how quickly she reached for Adora without even thinking about it. Scorpia’s right – she shouldn’t get her hopes up again. Leave it to Scorpia to make someone regret drunkenly confessing a crush by almost blurting it out in front of the person.

Catra quickly moves across the room to investigate the puddle. It’s thick, viscous but that doesn’t mean it isn’t just corn syrup and food coloring. She lightly handles Mermista’s discarded jacket, turning it over a couple times. There’s no holes, no tears or rips. So...someone stabbed her and she tossed it off cause it was too warm in there? This all screams set-up.

Barely restraining an eye roll now, Catra picks up the cracked thermometer. It’s the old analog kind of course, where the red arrow moves in a circle around the white face and tiny black numbers. The gauge must have gotten stuck when it broke cause it’s still set in the high 90s, which is definitely *not* the temperature in this room. In fact, it’s a lot closer to a human’s body temp, just a little below 100.

“Well,” Catra drolls and then takes a dramatic pause. “She’s done.”

Glimmer gasps loud enough to be heard across the room. “Are you seriously making jokes right now?”

“You're dressed like a ketchup bottle. You didn't get to say shit.”

"Catra's right. Mermista's probably just playing around," Lonnie agrees.

She throws herself onto one of the couches and relaxes. DT follows and does the same.

Catra is about to run an experimental claw through the red substance on the floor when Entrapta suddenly appears next to her.

"Can I look?" she asks but she moves so fast to touch everything that Catra has to reach and grab at her.

Entrapta just sidesteps her hand, surprisingly light-footed in her heavy boots. Catra's hand comes back empty as Entrapta skips from the pool of fluid to the jacket and back. It throws Catra off kilter – expecting to snatch at a pigtail and coming up with nothing – and she stumbles a bit. She's able to catch herself on the floor, except her hand doesn't land on the old, worn wooden boards. It lands right in the puddle, her palm and the sleeve of her jacket getting soaked.

"Fuck!" She tries to shake it off. "That's disgusting."

Catra raises her hand to glance at it for just a second before she heads towards the bathroom to clean up. The sight of her own palm saturated so thoroughly in red makes her freeze in her tracks. She's never seen this much of it at once, but that definitely *looks* and *smells* like…

"Blood," she says, dumbly. The thought makes Catra's stomach turn. This is actual real life blood. *Mermista's* blood.

"Are you sure?" Bow asks.

'Get ahold of yourself,' Catra thinks, chest starting to rise and fall too quickly. *'The last thing we need is these idiots running around in a panic.'*

But it’s already too late. Entrapta pops back over to stick her finger in as well and announce that Catra’s correct. Whatever front Lonnie and DT were putting on earlier is completely gone as their faces go slack in shock.

Scorpia has to rush to grab Kyle as he topples over. Glimmer helps Bow to a couch.

When Catra looks for Adora, she finds her best friend already kneeling down to help her to her feet.

“Here,” Adora says and she pulls some dusty old tissues out of a box on the nearby endtable. Her own hands shaking, she quickly tries to clean Catra up. “Glimmer, can you call the cops?”

“Already trying,” Sparkles mutters back. Her phone’s in her hand and the way she’s frantically pressing buttons doesn’t look effective at all.

“Come on,” Adora says, looking at Catra with worried eyes. “Let’s get you some water.”

“I’m fine.” Adora doesn’t look convinced even a little. “I promise.”

“It’s not going through,” Glimmer says.

“Try to make an emergency call,” Adora orders, voice full of authority.

That manages to reassure Catra. Mermista might just be a little more elaborate than usual in her shenanigans, but if something’s actually wrong, Adora’s there. She always was the leader, even when they were following Catra’s poorly thought-out schemes. Adora will know what to do, Catra repeats to herself as she tries to wrap her head around what’s happening.

“That’s not working either,” Glimmer responds, starting to sound frantic.

“Same,” Lonnie adds, also on her phone.

The others don't say anything – don't *need* to say anything. Scorpia and Bow's faces as they look at their own phones are enough for Catra to know.

"The library," she calls out. "There's a landline in the library. I'll just go-"

"I'm coming with you," Adora interrupts before she can finish.

"No," Glimmer argues. "No one should be alone right now. There's a killer here!"

"Agreed. Me and Entrapta will come too," Scorpia offers.

"So it's 3 against 1?" Glimmer asks.

Not liking what she's implying, Catra suggests. "Then you go."

Glimmer starts to shoot back, "So you can-"

"Shut *up!"* Lonnie cuts her off. *"I'll* go. Come on, Scorpia."

She pushes Scorpia in the back until they're both gone from view.

"Maybe you should take a couple breaths," Arrow tries to whisper to Glimmer.

"Like fuck I will! You heard Mermista – she said she knew where the money was kept. And now she's probably dead! I think someone wanted it for themself."

"We were all together though," Adora points out.

"It was dark. Someone could have broken off from the group and snuck back," DT observes. Their hair is pulled back in a long braid today and they twirl it as they think. "Besides Kitten and Blondie, no one was exactly using the buddy system to keep track of each other."

"Who was in the back?" Bow asks. "Someone had to be at the back of the group?"

“Me, I think,” Entrapta offers uncertainly. She frowns and Catra notices that her hand begins to nervously move towards her hair.

“It wasn't Entrapta,” Catra tells the others quickly. “Did you see anything weird, Trap? Anyone wander away?”

“I don't think so. But I wasn't paying very close attention. That *picture* – the one in the hall,” she clarifies, like she hasn't been spewing theories about it endlessly to Catra already, “It was... *warm.”*

“I told you. It's just *the pipes,”* Catra insists through gritted teeth.

In her peripheral, she sees Adora tilt her head in curiosity. Time to ease off the gas. The plan that Catra had roped Entrapta into only works if they’re able to run circles around these clueless dummies.

Nothing to see here, move along. Don’t think too much about why someone would be tracking the temperatures of the random creepy portraits that feel like they're staring back at you when you're not looking.

“Is this something we should check out?” Adora asks cause she’s too smart.

“Focus,” Glimmer interrupts and Catra tries not to look relieved. “Did anyone see *anything?* Anything suspicious? Someone looking shifty?”

“Just you,” DT answers, sweetly.

Hurried footsteps are pounding on the floorboards before Sparkles can lash out. Lonnie appears in the doorway first, panting and out of breath. Her eyes are wide. Catra’s witnessed Lonnie carry a soaking wet cardboard box that smelled like cow guts for Weaver and *this* is the only time she’s seen the girl look truly scared.

“Someone cut the line,” she tells them.

Scorpia catches up soon, winded as hell. “Not cut. They ripped the cord out of the wall. Damaged it. We ran upstairs and checked a couple of the bedrooms too. Same thing.”

DT is the only one to move as the others gape at Lonnie and Scorpia in confusion. In a couple of long steps, they glide around the blood on the floor and over to the bar.

“Well,” they say slowly. They wet their lips as they pick up a decanter of whiskey. “One of you clever dears is going to tell us what’s going on. Hordak wasn’t here long enough to disconnect the phones.”

“None of us were,” Lonnie replies.

Double Trouble takes out one of Weaver’s crystal cut highball glasses, the extra fancy ones that have the etched lines criss-crossing halfway up the sides. They pour a couple fingers worth of booze before taking a long sip.

After a brief pause, they say, “That’s not true though. *You* were here. Weren’t you...Scorpia?”

Scorpia’s claws shoot up to cover the lower half of her face. The way she tries to shrink herself down fails completely and Lonnie takes a step away, as if Scorpia might try to hide behind her.

“Of course!” she answers nervously. “But I’m always here! I live here, you know. To take care of the house and-and the Weavers. That’s what my family’s done for generations. We-I would *never* hurt anyone Ms. Weaver cared about.”

DT hums, watching Scorpia as she works herself up more and more into a lather.

“It’s alright, Scorp,” Catra tells her. “They’re just messing with you.”

Bow steps up to clear his throat. “Okay. Can I propose something? Why don’t we make a quick pact? We’ll all agree that one person

can leave and try to go get some help. And if this whole thing with your friend Mermista turns out to just be a prank, we swear that we won't tell Hordak that one of us got out of the mansion for a while."

It's a rational plan. One that Catra can agree to for now to ensure her own safety and then break and deny any knowledge of as soon as Mermista's found and it's time to claim the money.

"I think that's a great plan," Adora agrees. "We'll draw straws to see who should go."

"Nah. You and your sidekicks go," Lonnie suggests.

"That's an excellent idea," DT replies, taking another sip of their cocktail.

"Why us?" Adora asks.

Lonnie fixes her with a cold look. "We don't know you. You're outsiders. Bright Mooners. You could have set this whole thing up."

"Lonnie, I went to middle *and* high school with you," Adora argues.

"And the fact that you've witnessed some of my worst haircuts just makes you more expendable to me."

Adora looks to Catra for help. There's no one more trustworthy than Adora on the whole face of Etheria. But she's also intensely competitive, deeply in need of money. And she's the only one who knows all of Catra's tells. Worse, if they actually *are* in danger, Catra knows she'd probably do just about anything to keep Adora safe.

It's probably best to make sure the dummy is out of the house and unharmed anyway. Catra would never forgive herself if anything happened to Adora cause she got wrapped up in this mess.

Trying to think through the many different scenarios of how to handle this must take Catra too long because Kyle suddenly jumps up next to her.

“Fine! I’ll go!” he shouts. He's off and rushing out before anyone can stop him.

“Kyle!” Lonnie yells after him. “You’ve never been a hero. Why try to start now?”

The front door opens and slams shut.

“He doesn’t have a car,” Catra points out. “What the hell is he gonna do? Run 30 miles to the police station?”

Lonnie groans. “Godsdamnit! I’ll grab him and go to a neighbor’s.”

Grumbling the whole time, she heads out the door too. Perfect. Lonnie owes Catra $20 from a Wendy’s run. Cut her out of the inheritance and Catra will finally consider them even.

She follows to the door to keep an eye out. That fog was already coming in heavy in the afternoon. It’ll likely be damn near impossible to see as a human. Hopefully Kyle will be smart enough to stick to the footpath.

This house gives Catra a couple advantages over everyone. With all the creaking it does, she can usually figure out where everyone is. No one except Scorpia knows more of the hidden nooks and crannies than Catra does. And, most importantly, she’s probably the only one who can see much of anything through the weird mist that covers the grounds.

For a couple years in her teens, after Catra got over the initial eerie feeling the Weaver place gave her, she became convinced that everything that made the house so creepy was just parlor tricks. A smoke machine. Automatic lights that went on and off on a timer. Spooky sound effects on a loudspeaker.

That was just her brain trying to rationalize the unthinkable, Catra knows now. It's the kind of thing that Adora readily agreed to since she's a person who takes logic so seriously. Catra's open to a more otherworldly explanation. She *had* to be, after everything she's seen there.

Though, nothing so far has been as unbelievable as the sound of Kyle's voice, coming from the walkway, yelling "Emergency! Emergency!" over and over.

"What is that idiot doing?" she wonders aloud.

It's still hard to see that far ahead so she lowers a bit, hoping that half-squatting will get her close enough to the ground where the fog thins out some. There's a view of Kyle's legs and feet, standing next to the open gate. Entrapta has it camouflaged well into one of the iron bars, but Catra's one of only a handful of people who knows about the digital keypad that's a main part of the mansion's security system. It has a small speaker but Weaver sure as hell wouldn't have given her house a direct line to the cops or anything.

"Shit, Entrapta, he's trying to use the security keypad to call out. Can he even do that?" Catra can just barely hear Kyle yelling the address into the damn thing.

Her eyes keep scanning for Lonnie, who is nowhere in sight. She should have reached Kyle by now.

"Emergency! Operator! Operator!"

Entrapta appears at her side suddenly. "It's possible. If one had the correct code."

"Isn't an emergency the one time you'd want easy access?" Glimmer asks.

"I think Weaver's concern was more about making sure anyone couldn't get *out* in an emergency," Entrapta replies with a shrug

and Catra tries to ignore how that thought ensures it'll be just *that* much harder for her to sleep tonight.

Then Entrapta looks back to Catra and blinks once, like her friend's words are slowly hitting her. Catra watches as panic fills Entrapta, her eyes widening and her face paling before she turns in Kyle's direction again.

"Don't press anything!" Entrapta calls out towards the fog. "You'll engage th-"

Her words are cut off by a weird beeping noise and the ear-piercing sound of rusty old metal on rocks. It's worse than nails on a chalkboard, the kind of grating pain that makes Catra grit her teeth. Usually she tries to avoid this by leaving the gate unlocked and barely cracking it to slip in and out, taking solace in the fact that Weaver rarely left anymore and wouldn't know. But Scorpia had left the huge spooky thing wide open tonight. Now it's moving a hell of a lot faster than Catra expects, the hinges creaking like they're about to fall off as the gate begins to close.

Judging by his feet, Kyle's planning on bumbling around until he's crushed between the two heavy panels that make up the entrance. Kyle's been so hilariously ineffective at helping out Weaver over the past couple years that this newest blunder is truly on-brand. Catra would rather not see him end up as ground beef though so she makes to rush out and help him.

She's only stopped by a strong hand on her shoulder and a pincer blocking her movement. Adora helps pull Catra back up to a standing position as Scorpia takes off down the path.

"I'm on it, Wildcat!" she yells over her shoulder. Adora gives Catra a quick glance, trying to psychically convey "you'll be okay" it seems. When Catra nods, Adora follows quickly behind Scorpia.

Out of nowhere, Lonnie appears 4 feet in front of them, walking back up the path towards the porch.

"Where were you?" Glimmer asks.

With a frustrated grunt, Lonnie replies, “I got lost. Fucking murder fog.” She looks back towards Kyle, squinting.

Catra can hear a heavy metallic groaning as the gates come closer to latching together. She can just barely make out Scorpia and Adora up ahead, rushing towards Kyle as quickly as possible. Judging by all the shrieking he’s doing, he must be scared as all hell. Kyle steps backward frantically until he’s just outside the moving metal.

“Scorpia,” Entrapta screams. “If you don’t input the correct code, the system goes into panic mode.”

Lonnie glances back at her. “What does that mean?”

“Full lockdown. It’ll likely take me hours to override it before we can leave.”

They’ll be trapped. Everyone else probably has that thought at the same time because they all rush to the porch’s railing to stare uselessly out into the fog.

The gate isn’t slowing down, even as Scorpia reaches the keypad. The number of “oops” she’s letting out alongside the beeping tones isn’t comforting at all.

Adora is slower to reach Kyle. Too slow, actually. Catra can’t even see him anymore.

If everyone wasn’t already on the verge of wetting their pants, the disembodied howl that tears through the night certainly helps.

“Fuck no. That’s not happening,” Catra whispers, even as a second, different howl rings out. It sounds way too close. “I’ve lived in this neighborhood my whole life. We don’t have fucking wolves.”

“The forest isn’t dense enough,” Bow points out, voice on the verge of trembling. “And there’s too many people.”

There’s another howl. Catra swears this one sounds like it’s on the move.

“Well, *these* wolves don’t seem to know that,” Lonnie replies.

The gate latches with a loud, ominous click that makes Catra’s stomach feel like it’s dropping. Best case scenario, Mermista jumps out of a broom closet and Kyle runs the full 20 miles home.

The worst case scenario comes true when she hears a blood-curdling scream.

Entrapta removes her purple work mask from her front overall pocket and slips it over her head. The boxy shape, the amethyst color, the eyes glowing like two rubies, all just make her look more out of this world. She skitters off the porch and into the darkness, pigtails flying in the wind behind her.

Catra leaps off after her, dragging Lonnie by the hand so the idiot doesn't get lost again. The chill in the air, suddenly at least 10 degrees colder, rattles her more than losing sight of everyone almost immediately.

She just moves faster, unconcerned whether the pace is too much for Lonnie. Adora hasn't made a peep in minutes and her silence is pretty much the scariest sound Catra can imagine right now. Adora would dive into a wolf’s open mouth, even if it was to protect someone she barely cared about like Kyle. It's admirable, Catra can admit, but thoroughly dumb.

She and Lonnie catch up just as Entrapta rushes straight to the keypad that Scorpia probably shouldn't be fussing over anymore. Catra ignores her in favor of dropping Lonnie's hand and reaching for Adora's.

The blonde jumps in surprise as soon as Catra touches her.

“Sorry,” Adora mumbles when she sees Catra's face. She looks absolutely frightened. “I think I can see something on the

sidewalk.”

Catra bends to try to peek out into the darkness, through the gate’s posts.

Lonnie begins calling for Kyle but there's nothing. No sign of him or anything else, wolves included fortunately.

“Maybe we can climb over and find him,” Adora suggests, already reaching her hand out.

Entrapta's quick to yell out, “Don’t touch the gate! It’s-”

“Ow!!” Adora screams, pulling her hand back from it with a pained expression.

“-electrified,” Entrapta finishes. “Part of the lockdown protocol.”

“How's it going with getting this open?” Catra asks.

“I think I'll have to try it by getting into the system's mainframe,” she answers. The metal faceplate is already hanging off it, wires pulled out. “Good thing I brought my workstation.”

The vibe's grim as fuck when everyone is gathered back in the sitting room and Catra can't blame them. That's two people down in less than an hour. With numbers like those, there might not be anyone left by morning.

Assuming this isn't all someone's dumbass idea of a joke, Catra reminds herself.

Entrapta works on her laptop, staring unblinkingly at the screen while everyone else mostly paces about the room. DT tries to pretend they're above this by continuing to drink. But Catra can see the cracks, the way their tail won't stay still and how they smell like panicked sweat.

“So,” Bow starts. “We're trapped by a gate that’s electrified. Two people have disappeared. And there’s no way to get help.”

“We could dig our way out,” Glimmer suggests.

“Sure, you start and we’ll catch up,” Lonnie replies, dryly. Seated on the couch next to Catra, she reaches into her pocket and pulls out a packet of reds. But instead of taking out a cigarette, she whips out a joint.

“Hey, you think we should maybe stay sober and alert if there’s actually someone trying to kill us?” Catra asks.

Lonnie ignores her to put the joint to her lips and light it. “This is a stressful situation. I need to relax!” she mumbles with the j still hanging from her mouth.

Scorpia makes a nervous face. She's probably thinking about how much Weaver hated smoking in the house, even though they were constantly burning much more toxic shit than bud.

“Also, you drank a pint of whiskey,” Lonnie points out, before casually attempting to pass the joint.

“And I can't be fucking cross-faded right now.” Catra pushes her hand away.

Out of the corner of her eye, Catra catches Adora giving her a weird look, like the one she gave Scorpia and even Mermista earlier. The one she gave Lonnie when they were kids.

It's normal for Adora to be jealous. She and Catra were thick as thieves their whole lives. If anyone else came around, it was hard for them to learn to share. So this is all just them still adjusting to having to see each other with additional friends. They don't just belong to each other anymore.

Almost like she wants to prove that, Sparkles crosses the room to stand next to Adora at the mantle.

“What do you think we should do?” she asks. Glitter’s using this fucking scared baby voice that almost makes Catra annoyed enough to actually consider getting stoned to block it out. With

big round lilac eyes, she stares up at Adora like their lord and savior.

Fucking simp.

Adora bites her lower lip for a moment, before saying, "I think Entrapta and Scorpia were right. Everyone should take a room and lock themself inside. Don't open the door. Under any circumstances."

"Don't worry about setting any alarms, friends," DT says with a smile. "I'll be sure to wake you all up bright and early."

"Like anyone is fucking sleeping tonight," Glimmer grumbles.

Catra doesn't last 20 minutes. Not when she can hear every single person cause her nerves are on high alert.

She's never actually slept over at Weaver's. Before, she would have said you couldn't pay her enough to do so but apparently the promise of untold riches was sufficient. There's no way she's getting any rest in the room Scorpia placed her in, hemming and hawing about how it was the best one in the house.

Everything has frills and a layer of dust. There's no less than 6 antique dolls sitting on the dresser, waiting to steal your soul and/or be used as a deadly weapon if needed. Each has porcelain skin, empty bluebell eyes, and what Catra is *sure* is human hair.

Within minutes, she says 'later days' and pokes around until she finds what she's come to expect all over the house. A hidden passageway. This one's not even hidden *well*. She moves the creepy doll dresser over a little and there's a tiny door right there, just small enough to fit a kid into.

Well, that's a fucking creepy thought.

It's freezing inside, trapped between the wooden slats that comprise the walls. The space is just narrow enough for her thin

body. It’s pitch black, but Catra’s night vision gives her an advantage to move around freely, dodging cobwebs. That moist earthy smell might be stuck in her nose forever though.

The cold kinda makes her regret ditching her jacket back in the room. Something about seeing Mermista’s blood on the sleeve – even if it was probably fake – made Catra feel a little sick to her stomach.

This all feels like the plot of one of those Mer-Mystery books that Mermista always kept tucked into her jacket pocket. She’d been waiting her whole life to crack some kind of secret plot. Mermista’s probably slinking around some passageway taking secret notes on everyone and trying to frame Kyle for getting himself kidnapped by wolves.

Gods, this whole thing is so stupid. There’s probably not even any money. Weaver was such a fucking liar that she couldn’t even answer a question straight. Catra tried to ask what her first name was once and she accused Catra of attempting to “steal her power.” Like anyone wants whatever ancient curse that’s definitely been placed on her whole lineage and this nightmare house.

The doors that open and close on their own. The way you can sometimes see a person in the window from the street even when the house is definitely empty once you get there. Knives falling off their hooks on the wall. Weird flower smells when there’s not a single living plant on the property. That “Perfuma” that Scorpia talks to sometimes but who always ‘disappears’ before Catra gets there. The second she said Perfuma showed up wearing a wet dress one day *when the gate was locked*, Catra walked right out of the house and didn’t come back for a solid week.

At least Adora’s there. Catra practically skipped over as soon as she saw her face. So pathetic. Adora’s focused on following her dreams and going to med school. She doesn't have time for Catra to still be holding onto some childhood crush that’s never gonna happen.

It could be worse though. She could be as transparent and pitiful as Sparkles. That dummy took one look at Adora as a kid and fell like a very very obvious brick. Catra's still convinced Glimmer gave up on going to that fancy private school on the other side of the country just so she could follow Adora to Bright Moon U.

Something scurries by her foot and Catra has to throw herself against the wall to avoid it.

"What the fuck is that?!?" she hears Lonnie yell through the wall.

There's some rustling in the room but Catra hightails it further down the passage. She's doing a perfectly good job of repressing any and all thoughts of what could have happened to Kyle so it's easy to ignore the weird creak and muffled scream that follows her.

Scorpia has to be around here somewhere. Catra could have sworn she was staying up here to keep a close eye on her friends, instead of returning to her own room downstairs in the 'servant's quarters', Weaver called them. If Entrapta's theories about the warm spots in the house and the secrets hidden behind them are true, they'll need someone strong with a deep knowledge of the mansion. And Scorpia's such a loving goober that if she's not with Catra and Entrapta, she'll probably be the next one to mysteriously disappear. It's important to stay close, just in case.

The next room she passes is definitely the Glitter Twins'. Glimmer never learned how to whisper so Catra can hear her entire side of the conversation as she sneaks by.

"I shouldn't have never worked here. I didn't even learn anything helpful and Weaver was always up to weird shit and ughhh!" Sparkles whines. "My mom was right."

"Angella was being overprotective," Bow tells her, much more quietly.

Catra doesn't exactly agree. No parent in their right mind would be fine with their kid hanging out with the town outcast in her

haunted mansion. She had to lie to her own mom for years about where she and Adora were getting money from.

"Catra's in on all of this, you know. Every shady thing Weaver was up to. Probably whatever crap Hordak's trying to pull. We can't trust her."

"Do you think you might be mad at Catra for other reasons?" Bow says softly.

Not wanting any part of that, Catra keeps it moving. She passes what definitely sounds like DT practicing at sounding surprised, their voice going up at different points in the statement each time.

"Oh? I'm not sure what happened to everyone. That's *so* odd." They clear their throat. "I'm not sure *what* happened to everyone. That's so *odd."*

It sounds like they're smiling. Catra knocks on the wall three times just to scare the shit out of them.

"Bloody Mary?!?" DT screams.

The next room is silent. Even better, a few of the slats are loose, covering up a small wooden panel that's about 4 feet tall and 2 feet wide. That means there's probably some way to easily open it from inside the room. Catra has to extend her claws but she's able to slip one between the door and the makeshift door jamb and wiggle it in until she's got enough leverage to slide the panel open.

"If you're coming in to kill me, you should know that I have a black belt in judo," Adora calls out. "And also a knife."

"You should have led with the knife, dummy," Catra grunts out.

She's able to get the panel pushed out of the way, tucked into the wall somewhere. But now there's something huge and heavy blocking her entrance into the room. Pushing on it doesn't seem to be doing shit.

Suddenly, it pops right out of the way and Catra has to adjust her weight so that she doesn't fall into the room and look like a dumbass in front of her lifetime obsession.

Okay, not like... *obsession.* That's creepy. Infatuation, maybe. Gay awakening?

"Hey," said gay awakening whispers, reaching out a strong, lightly callused hand to pull Catra through the wall.

She has to duck low to get through the small spot. When she straightens out, Adora doesn't make any moves to step back and give Catra much personal space.

Catra's kinda aware that she's standing next to a full fucking 7-foot tall armoire that Adora must have moved like it was light as air just to see her. But all she can really focus on is the angel in front of her.

Thankfully, Adora's out of that dumb hot dog. She's replaced it with tight faded black jeans, a baggy cream-colored cable knit sweater, a white tee shirt peeking out underneath, and beat up black canvas sneakers.

Her blonde hair's falling down into her eyes and Catra can smell her coconut milk shampoo or whatever. Not that she remembers what kind of shampoo Adora uses because that would be weird.

Her face is made of more sharp angles now, cheekbones more defined and chin pointy like a comic book hero. Her eyes – which are *bluer* somehow if that's possible – look like they're squinting.

"Are you okay?" Adora asks. That's another different thing. The voicemails Catra saved all capture a higher-pitched, unsure tone. But Adora sounds more confident now. Her voice is almost light and musical. "Wait. Did you hit your head on the way in?"

"What?" Catra reluctantly tosses Adora's hand down to quickly dash further into the room. "You should probably close that. Just in case."

Adora squints at her some more but eventually goes to do just that. Catra uses the distraction to smooth her clothes down, making sure there's no dust or bugs on her. Casually. Like one does when they have visitors.

The armoire gets pushed back into place like it's nothing. It's...nice that Adora still works out. Good for her health or something.

She turns back to Catra with a smile that's just a little awkward.

"Don't lecture me about not following the rules," Catra says.

"I wasn't going to," Adora huffs, still smiling. "I know it's useless to tell you to be safe. You've already made up your mind about what you're gonna do anyway."

"I'm keeping my options open," Catra replies, because she thinks it sounds mysterious.

Adora just raises her eyebrows in response. "Okay…."

Catra glances around the room. It's not a doll-filled hellscape but it's no more warm and cozy. The dark walnut bedframe has little angels carved into it, alongside palms or something and weird loops.

"That was definitely made to guilt you into not fornicating before marriage," she mumbles.

Adora looks at it for a second and giggles. "Yeah. As soon as I saw it, I thought of that time you were listing off a bunch of random old timey things that were created to prevent masturbation."

"Graham crackers," Catra replies with a nod, remembering the time she researched a bunch of boring topics to tamper down some of the *much more than friendly* thoughts she was having about her best friend. "Never looked at those the same way again."

“Corn flakes,” Adora adds.

Yep. Catra thinks it’s probably a good idea to picture something like how gross soggy cereal can be and not that time in senior year when she accidentally walked in on Adora moaning in the shower during a sleepover. The whole incident really made the pieces come together in Catra’s mind. After that moment, she was no longer a confused kid having weird thoughts about her BFF. She was an adult – old enough to vote at least – who was definitely a huge lesbian and also about to immediately die from hormone overload.

It was actually slightly less alarming than when Adora stormed into her room without knocking a couple months later and caught Catra in an embarrassing situation with a magazine photo of some blonde blue-eyed pro soccer player.

Their eyes meet for a second before Adora’s cheeks start to turn a lovely pale pink. Her eyes look just a little farther away, like she’s suddenly thinking about something. Then they widen slightly, her lips parting, and Adora’s back in the present.

She joins Catra in nodding absently. Now they’re just two idiots staring at each other and failing at *not* thinking about touching themselves.

The idea makes Catra’s stomach clench. She has to fight not to make it noticeable.

“Are you cold?” Adora asks, eyes looking worried as she takes in Catra’s bare arms in her cut-up sleeveless shirt. “Uh...here!”

Immediately, Adora whips off her sweater to hand it over. That tshirt she has on underneath is a lot tighter than what Catra is adequately prepared for. Adora has...grown. Particularly in the tits, shoulders, and biceps. Her forearms look like a damn pro wrestlers’.

The sweater slips right out of Catra’s hands and to the floor cause apparently she doesn’t have basic motor skills anymore.

“Cool,” she mumbles.

Adora laughs, a sound that Catra kinda wants to live in forever. The blonde follows Catra’s eyes to her own arms. She’s definitely not imagining that Adora flexes slightly.

A throat clears awkwardly. Catra blinks quickly and Adora’s smirking way too smugly when she’s able to force herself to look back up to her face.

“Cool,” Adora tosses back to her. She reaches down to pick up the sweater that’s been abandoned at Catra’s feet.

Except, instead of just handing it over again, Adora moves closer and gently pulls it over Catra’s head. The material is soft. It tickles her nose and Adora smiles at the way she scrunches her face up.

And then those hands, the ones Catra’s missed so much, reach down to grab her wrist, putting it through the sleeve before doing the same on the other side. Adora even rolls the sleeves up so they’re not too long, but Catra’s practically drowning in the sweater regardless.

It smells like Adora. Like memories and shared secrets and a place to belong.

Adora’s fingers slowly comb through her mane, probably trying to help put it back in place. Tentatively, they sneak down to the shaved sides, a place so sensitive that Catra doesn’t let anyone touch it except her barber. The pads of Adora’s fingertips feel soothing as they make contact with Catra’s skin, even as it feels like an electric current shoots down her spine, ending in her extending tail.

“You changed your hair,” Adora says softly. “I like it.”

“Yeah?” Catra whispers back. Completely unconsciously, a soft purr starts in her chest. So Adora stays, still petting her even when there’s no need anymore. Her thumb lingers on the

hypersensitive buzzed area while the rest of her fingers move back into Catra's curly mane. "No poof?"

"I forgot to pack a ponytail holder," she replies with a shrug.

Catra slips a hand into her jean pocket and pulls one out. Adora doesn't reach to take it. Gently, she tilts her head in Catra's direction. It's weirdly hard to tie someone's hair up while they're petting through yours but Catra manages to do it with minimal fumbling, pulling Adora's bangs back into their signature poof.

She's not quite sure what to do with herself now that that task is complete so Catra's hands find their way to Adora's upper back, trailing along the muscles near her shoulder blades.

Adora quietly hums a few times, the human version of purring that she picked up when they were tiny and she always wanted to mimic everything Catra did.

"How are you?" Adora asks.

"So good," Catra sighs, her eyes starting to drift closed on their own. This is pretty much heaven.

"Oh." The gentle touches stop abruptly. Adora takes a stumbling step back. "That's good to hear. That you're doing so well these days, I mean."

Catra frowns. She's completely lost. This dummy is turning red and trying to stare at everything in the room except her.

But Adora just won't stop talking, continuing a conversation that Catra struggles to keep up with. "I'm doing well too, just so you know. School was hard but it was great. And I'm working now while I study for the MCATs. My apartment isn't too bad either. Small. But much better than the dorms."

"O...kay? Good for you," Catra replies, hoping it doesn't sound sarcastic. She wasn't prepared for Adora to brag about how

amazing her life is. But that makes sense. Adora always had dreams that were too big and beautiful for the Fright Zone.

“You still over at your mom’s place? How’s she doing?”

“Yeah, it’s fine. She’s fine. Same as always.”

“Um, what are you doing here?”

“I was looking for Scorpia,” Catra answers. She’s still trying to catch up to what’s happening. There was a time where she used to know what was happening in Adora’s head without even having to think about it. But that line seems to have been severed.

Was intentionally severed, really. By Catra. So that Adora didn’t have to feel obligated to come back for it.

“Scorpia?” Adora’s jaw tightens, even as she tries to force herself to smile. “Well, you can go.”

That stings. It more than stings, actually. It’s a papercut and a stubbed toe and a bug flying in your eye all at once. Catra has to stuff her hands into her pockets to make sure she’s not fidgeting under Adora’s annoyed eyes.

“Sorry I was such a bother, I guess,” she mumbles. There’s no way to stop her ears from giving her away. But maybe if she’s lucky, Adora will take it as anger and not pure sadness from being rejected.

Catra turns on her heel to leave quickly. She can’t ask Adora to move the armoire again and she’s not even sure which room Scorpia’s in now. The door is the only option. Honestly, dealing with a possible intruder is probably preferable to having Adora dismiss her.

“You weren’t!” Adora says quickly, voice a lot louder than it needs to be. She jumps in between Catra and the door. “I just thought you were busy.”

“We’re trapped here all night, Dor. I don’t exactly have places to be.” That’s not entirely true but the plan can wait.

Adora nods like she’s not even listening.

“We should sleep together,” she says suddenly.

As soon as the words are out into the distance between them, Adora’s eyes go wide, as if she never meant to propose that. Her mouth opens and closes a couple more times uselessly.

Catra goes to ask what the hell is so weird about that, considering that they’ve done it one million times, when Adora regains the ability to speak.

“I meant...uh. Later! In the bed! Asleep! Together,” her words are filled with an increasing level of panic until she tries to make a serious ‘business’ face at the end. “It'll give us more time to talk and catch up?”

A quiet chuckle leaps out of Catra. “You’re an idiot. Since when did you get so-”

“-ill *not* calm down,” Catra’s ears pick up coming from outside the door. “We’re the only two who are in a group. We have to confront Adora and whoever’s in there with her for putting us all in danger.”

Bow’s voice chimes in to point out, “It’s pretty ironic to break a rule just to yell at someone for breaking a rule.”

Adora grabs Catra’s hand to get her attention. “What do you hear?”

A loud knock on the door is enough of an answer.

“Adora!” Glimmer yells, before knocking again.

The blonde just grimaces.

“Sorry,” she whispers. “Glim’s pretty protective.”

“I bet,” Catra mutters to herself. She’s sure that Sparkles knows exactly who's in this room and what she believes she’s interrupting.

There’s more voices joining them out in the hall now. Entrapta asking questions. Scorpia reminding everyone to go back to their rooms.

In a couple long strides, Adora reaches the door, unlocks it, and pulls it open. Glimmer and Bow are bunched up against the doorframe, with the rest of the group hovering behind them. Thankfully they’ve changed out of their dumb costumes. Unfortunately, the two of them are wearing *matching* violet-colored tracksuits.

Not a single member of the group looks worried. Maybe Scorpia. Mostly they all just look curious and too interested in what’s happening in Adora’s room. Especially Glitter.

“Is everything okay in here?” Bow asks. “We heard raised voices.”

Adora laughs nervously, which does nothing to reassure anyone. “Yeah, we’re fine. Me and Catra are just having a private conversation. No need to worry.”

Those curious glances immediately shift to suspicion cause Adora’s acting so weird. Catra has to move to the doorway and shove the dummy aside.

“We’re fine. Mind your business and go back to bed.”

Glimmer ignores her completely. “Adora, how did she convince you to unlock the door and let her in? Don’t you know that we’re all in danger?”

“She’s not some innocent idiot who I just led astray, Sparkles.”

Adora puts a protective hand onto her shoulder. “Yeah, I’ve gotten Catra into a lot more trouble than she’s gotten me into.”

“Well, my plans are always better,” Catra says, turning to grin up at her.

“You’re just stealthier.”

“I’ll take speed over muscle any day.”

Adora smirks and her grip tenses in a way that means that she’s probably flexing again. “Is that so?”

“Stop flirting!” Glimmer yells. “Why are you wearing her shirt?!”

“Good question,” DT purrs. “And why are you out of your room, Kitten?”

The nickname makes Adora’s grip tighten on her shoulder. Catra has to fight not to lean into it further. DT’s handy in a shitty situation. But only as long as they don’t have any leverage to use to their advantage.

“I’m not sure if this matters but Lonnie is missing,” Entrapta observes.

Everyone rushes to look around the group and count, as if the literal genius among them can’t get up to 8 on her own.

“Shoo-fly pie!” Scorpia yells.

“Is that your version of cursing?” Glimmer asks.

Again, Lonnie’s even shiftier than Mermista. She probably just wandered off to steal.

That sound in her room could have been anything. Maybe she and Mermista are even working together. Lonnie always did have a thing for her.

“May I suggest that this is a perfect moment for the rest of us remaining here to assemble in one room for safety,” Entrapta says.

“Perhaps we can move a second bed into one of the larger rooms, lock ourselves in, and take shifts sleeping?”

“Wait!” Glimmer interrupts. “You don’t think one of *us* is the problem here, do you?”

“There *is* a very limited pool of suspects,” DT comments.

Bow raises both hands in a sign of good will. “I think this is a great idea, Entrapta. Let’s all just-”

He’s cut off by the lights all going out. Not just someone flipping a switch. No, this is a full blackout, every bulb, lamp, and creepy ancient sconce dimming at once. With the heavy curtains, they’re plunged into total darkness.

This is fine, Catra thinks. In a second, she’ll at least be able to-

Before Catra’s eyes have time to adjust, someone *screams*.

Chapter End Notes

> i said catra would look great in ransom's sweater and i stand behind that.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

happy catra day! have a long chapter!

we're alternating catra and adora povs a few times today, with the voice changing at each horizontal line. maybe we'll even get some insight into another person's thoughts...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Sorry for yelling,” Bow says as Glimmer examines him for any wounds. “I’m just not very comfortable with darkness.”

The nightlight in his room makes a lot more sense now.

There’s still no cell service but at least everyone’s able to use their phones as makeshift flashlights so they’re not all stumbling around in the dark. It would be helpful if they weren’t all accidentally shining them in each other’s eyes. Particularly Catra’s, which are so sensitive. Everytime Adora catches sight of her, she’s grimacing and quietly hissing at someone.

“Hey,” Adora whispers to her. “I’m on your left.”

Catra mutters something back, probably pointing out that that’s obvious to her since she’s the one who can actually see the best. But she quiets down when Adora places her hand back on Catra’s shoulder.

Their convo in her room was weird. Comforting and distant and old and new all at the same time. But at this moment, all Adora knows is that she has to keep Catra close.

Glimmer reaches out for her other hand and Adora lets her, smaller fingers wrapping around her wrist.

The tension’s the thickest it’s been so far, which is really saying a lot since three of them are *missing.* If someone’s actually out to get them, they’re all sitting ducks in this hall. Limited vision, no weapons.

Adora decides to take the lead. “Everyone, try to remain calm. It’s probably just an issue with the electricity. This is an old house, after all. Maybe we can look for the circuit breaker and check it?”

“Great idea,” Catra agrees. “Scorpia, do you know where it is?”

Everyone swivels their phone to her face. She has to squint and it just makes her look extra suspicious. Adora usually doesn't get a bad vibe from people but Scorpia puts her on high alert for some reason.

“I do not, Wildcat. Can't say I've had to deal with any problems like this before. Not until this lot showed up tonight.” With her pincer, she gestures at Adora and her friends, like this could somehow be *their* fault.

“Let's break up into two teams and look for it,” Bow suggests. He’s always been better at fake politeness.

Everyone turns their phone towards him, stunning him too.

“Maybe cool it with lights for a bit?” Adora tells them all.

A soft touch flutters down her back. With her anxiety so high, Adora surprises herself by not immediately overreacting. But instinctively, she knows what that sensation is. It's Catra's tail unconsciously transmitting its owner's gratitude. Adora moves to reach for it with her left hand but Glimmer must get scared cause she holds onto Adora's wrist even tighter.

DT clears their throat. “I’m not opposed to splitting up but maybe we should think about how to protect ourselves?”

Once again, Catra looks to Scorpia as if she has all the answers. “Weaver keep any guns in the house?”

Scorpia looks completely lost. Glimmer cuts her nervous dancing off with a sigh.

"I'll check the kitchen for the circuit breaker," Glimmer announces. "And I'll grab the *biggest* knife I can find while I'm in there. Bow, Adora, you should come with-"

Catra interrupts her. "A knife, huh? Those take a lot of guts, you know. Since you have to get in so close to use them." She takes a step towards Glimmer. "You get close to Mermista earlier?"

Glimmer makes an outraged sound similar to a growl. "*You're* accusing me of something?! You were the only person out of your room and now Lonnie's missing and the power's out."

"Catra was standing here with all of us when everything went dark," Adora points out.

"You don't have to defend her!" Glimmer replies.

Adora ignores that to turn to Catra. "And Glimmer has no reason to want to hurt Mermista."

"I'd say money's a huge reason," Catra responds. "She knows more than she's telling. None of you are as pure as you're pretending to be."

Bow raises his voice, stern and out of patience. "Enough. The three of us will check the kitchen. Scorpia, can you take everyone else?"

She nods quickly. "We'll head down to the basement."

Not even bothering to seem less obvious, Scorpia uses her pincer to push Adora's hand away from Catra and lead the latter away, down the hall.

At first Catra thinks it's just bad luck that DT ends up following them downstairs and into the lowest level of the house. And then

just as they're descending into the basement, DT opens their mouth for the first time and puts that delusion to rest.

"Kitten, I knew you'd been pining badly for *someone.* I hadn't realized blondes with a protective streak were your type." They're silent for a moment and she doesn't bother looking back to see what they're up to. Scorpia's squirming next to her is distracting enough while Catra's trying to keep an eye out for any possible danger. "Well, maybe that's just exclusive to *one* blonde."

Scorpia raises her arm to awkwardly toy at her hair. Catra swallows a sigh. Yes, Scorpia's stepped up to fill the role of 'overprotective friend' in Catra's life and honestly, she'd pass on it completely if she weren't afraid of crushing the other girl's feelings. Scorpia took over as butler at the Weaver place only a couple of years ago, replacing her mother, who mostly ignored whatever weird shit was happening there. At first, Catra expected Scorpia to do the same until all the little things started up – surprise snacks, reminders not to stay too late, help carrying stuff around the house. Scorpia even stood up to Weaver a couple times when she and Catra fought.

Completely against her will, Catra had found a good friend in Scorpia. She just maybe needed some space from her sometimes.

It's nothing like what she has with Adora – Scorpia means something entirely different to her. Even though things between them are a little awkward and complicated, Adora's the place that Catra always returns to. Scorpia's caring and kind but it doesn't mean anything to her. It's not unusual for DT to read all the signals wrong though, just to cause chaos.

Behind her, step-in-step with DT, Entrapta pauses swinging her flashlight wildly from side to side.

"Catra, I didn't know you had a romantic type. What other common characteristics do you look for in a mate?" Entrapta asks.

“The faster the lights are back on, the faster you can return to trying to hack the gate,” Catra reminds her.

“Actually, shouldn’t we just go try to pry it open now? If there’s no electricity, the gate shouldn't be all...electrified, right?” Scorpia asks.

“Actually, the gate is attached to a backup generator. I checked and it’s still on the grid. It’s odd that the *house* didn’t shift to the backup power source as well, though.”

DT hums a little. “Yes, odd. Almost like someone planned it that way. Any idea who would have the skill to do that, Entrapta? Besides you, of course.”

“Well, many people would probably have the skill. Though few would have an intimate and detailed knowledge of the mansion, its security systems, and its overall infrastructure.”

“So one single person would have trouble pulling this off. But not a group of, say, two or three?”

There’s a slight emphasis on ‘three’ that Catra is annoyed about until they reach the end of the stairs and she has to shift all brainpower towards be wholly fucking unsettled.

Weaver’s half-finished basement stretches out before them, extending throughout most of the house. It’s a labyrinth, a shockingly huge space that contains two long halfways that run perpendicular, a few rooms, and more than one door that seems to be sealed shut. Catra knows that following the hallway they’re in to the right leads to the ‘lab,’ the largest room down there. Or at least, the largest one Catra’s been allowed in. It’s more like an apothecary really, with shelves of brown bottles lining the walls, all filled with herbs, tinctures, and essences. In the center sits the workstation, its appearance closer to a perfumery than a chemistry set, where Weaver toiled constantly. Where Catra did as well, usually.

Weaver may have *called* DT an apprentice but they never once sat at that station. Possibly because of that knowledge, Catra's hesitant to take them that way tonight. Instead they go north, heading towards the back of the house.

The ground is lined with cement and their footsteps echo on it too loudly in the quiet space. It sounds like Scorpia's dragging her arm against the drywall but that's probably just because of how narrow the hall is. Due to the complete lack of windows down here, it's even darker than upstairs. Everyone except her leads with their phones but Catra can't imagine that gives them more than a few feet of clear vision in front of themselves.

They find the circuit breaker along the back wall. Catra's expecting a silver metal door guarding a series of black switches. Maybe that's fucking naive, since this house is ancient and also the most confusing and inefficient place imaginable.

What she stumbles upon is 30 or so multi-colored open wires attached to a white plastic switch. They're all tangled and she's pretty sure some of them even look burned.

"What the hell is this?" she asks.

Entrapta thrusts herself forward, phone already lifted to investigate. "Wooooow."

"Uh, is it supposed to look like that?" Scorpia chimes in.

"Well, Weaver insisted on hiring someone else to actually wire my security system. And I believe a different person was brought on to do most of the physical setup. I was strictly forbidden from learning who."

The old woman didn't want them all to know what they were doing, Catra's brain fills in for her. It's a pretty classic Weaver tactic to create as much secrecy as possible.

Entrapta continues on, "So this is the first time I'm actually seeing the wiring. But no, I'd say whoever did this either had no idea

how to build an electrical system. Or they *did* and just...chose this?"

"Nevermind that," DT says, like they're reading Catra's desperation to move on. "Can you fix it?"

"I could. Maybe! I'd need my equipment. I'll just go up and grab it."

She tries to take off before anyone can say anything. Catra has to grab one of her pigtails to stop her.

"Hold up. We're not separating," she says.

"It'll be much faster alone!" Entrapta insists.

"As you pointed out, Kitten, the quicker the power's back on, the quicker we can start to get out of here."

Catra moves her eyes away to respond to DT. "Yeah, but we still need Entrapta in one piece for that."

It's just enough of a distraction that the pigtail in her hand slips away. Catra lunges for it but Entrapta scurries away down the hall.

"A few of these look burned," Scorpia mumbles quietly. "Am I making that up?"

DT steps closer to examine the wires. "Any theories on who would do such a thing? The Bright Moon pack, perhaps?"

"Oooh, another warm spot," Catra hears behind her.

Immediately, her ears perk up. But before she can turn and remind Entrapta not to bring any attention to those, a door opens in the distance.

In an instant, it slams shut again. The thud is so loud that Scorpia jumps in fear.

"Entrapta, what the hell was that?!" Catra yells.

She waits several seconds but no answer comes. An instinct – or maybe just a shit ton of paranoia – calls out to her. Entrapta's easily distracted but even she knows where their priorities are right now. She wouldn't just abandon this electrical mystery to dive into something else. Or Catra hopes as much.

She goes with her gut, dropping down on all fours to take off after Entrapta as quickly as possible. The echo had come from the southwest corner of the basement, one of the sections that was always off-limits.

Reaching the first of the two doors down there, Catra pushes the first one open but makes sure to remain in the hall just in case. It's a mostly empty room, storage for some excess cleaning products. The second door, a couple feet to the left...it feels *warm.* Like, the temperature in the air just outside changes slightly. Even touching the doorknob doesn't give the sensation of cool metal that Catra would expect.

It doesn't budge. The knob doesn't turn at all. There's no keyhole so no way to unlock it from outside. More importantly, no way for her to pick it. The brass knob is ancient and all solid, not the modern type that can lock themselves. So logically, there should be nothing keeping this door from opening.

She tries force instead, knowing it'll probably fail. Catra pulls and pulls. She even puts her feet on the wall for extra leverage but nothing happens.

Scorpia finds her that way and takes over quickly. The doorknob creaks like it might just fall off instead of actually turning.

"Entrapa! Are you inside?" Catra yells.

DT's light is scanning the rest of the hall. "Are you sure this is the way she came?"

"Yes," Catra hisses. "This is where the door slammed."

Scorpia lets go of the knob to point.

“Uh...Wildcat?” she asks awkwardly. “Did you see this?”

Catra gives the door a long look. What she’s seeing is absolutely impossible though. This is the door Entrapta went into.

Except. Two strips of wood are nailed into each side of the door and connected to the wall.

It’s sealed. It’s *been* sealed for awhile, judging by how decrepit the wood is.

“So,” DT begins. “Where the hell is Entrapta?”

There’s nothing in the kitchen. Adora is kind enough to finally take that forgotten roast out of the oven cause apparently Scorpia isn’t bothered about finishing a job correctly. It's charred, barely resembling food anymore. When she dumps it in the trash, it drops like a stone.

“No circuit breaker here,” Bow announces.

“Let's try the pantry,” Adora suggests.

Glimmer manages to give her a small smile. “Sure this isn't just a con for you to grab some food?”

“It wasn't but I won't complain if that's how it works out for me. It’s Halloween – I was hoping for a little sugar tonight at the party.” Adora smirks at her. Even in the dark, Glimmer's cheeks look flushed. She's always so easy to tease.

It's funny how similar Glimmer and Catra are to each other, while in some ways, they couldn't be more different. They're both so independent, such fierce personalities. The kind of friends who'd throttle someone for messing with you. But Glimmer's more sheltered than Catra, who had to start taking care of herself so early with her mom working all the time to keep food on the table. Catra plays her cards close to the vest; Glimmer tends to scream her entire plan right into your face.

It was a mess anytime they spent more than a couple minutes together once Glimmer entered Weaver's place. She was looking for whatever "skills" the old woman claimed to have been cultivating for years. But Glimmer's lessons were mostly odd, vague parables. Weaver lectured her about power and control, while Adora filled bottles and bottles of something she was too young to understand and too smart to ask more about. Meanwhile, Catra threw herself into the technical side, completely disinterested in any broader meaning of the work.

It was usually harder to rile Catra up, no matter how hard Adora tried. Yet, Glimmer was always expressive. It was kinda odd though that Bow didn't have that same effect on her, when Adora was absolutely certain that the two of them had been crushing on each other for the past couple years since they met him at freshman orientation. Glimmer had even openly admitted that she had her eye on someone for a while, someone close to them that she was working up the courage to confess to.

"Hey, a couple more lights here please?" Bow calls out.

Adora scrambles over to join him in the pantry. It's little more than a narrow half-hallway, shelves built into the walls. She imagines they're still full of expired cans of food. Weaver never once ate in front of them, never had the house smelling of a prepared meal.

She aims her phone for the walls, looking for a small metal door, while Bow does the same. Glimmer seems to have given up. She's holding one of her arms against her body, cradling her elbow with her phone in the same hand, shining absently against the floor.

It's too much to hope for something edible in this room. The huge aluminum cans all contain baked beans and stewed tomatoes and other things that Adora doesn't have time to try to figure out how to build a meal from.

She lucks out though. Pretending to look for the breaker on a lower shelf, she stumbles on exactly what she's looking for. Adora glances towards Glimmer and Bow but neither of them are paying

attention. They probably wouldn't be able to see her in the dark anyway. Score.

Adora accidentally makes much more noise than she intends, the bag rustling as she shoves it into her pocket.

"What's that?" Glimmer asks. Her phone swivels to catch Adora throwing her palms up in a fake show of innocence.

"Nothing," Adora says quickly.

"I'm not seeing it," Bow tells them. He seems to notice that they stopped helping for the first time. "What's up, guys?"

"Adora's being weird and lying."

"I'm not lying. I just *am* weird."

Glimmer harrumphs. "Well, that's true. This house is making you act weider. You and Catra are all buddy-buddy all of a sudden."

It's a reflex but Adora immediately feels her shoulders rise towards her ears. "Catra's my friend. She's been there for me my whole life so don't-"

"Not in the past 4 years," Glimmer counters. "She completely disappeared on you. And now she's here cause there's money. Isn't that suspicious to you?"

Honestly, it's not. Catra's as much a victim of Weaver's games as the rest of them are. She does seem to be up to something. Like she pointed out though, they're all keeping some sort of secret. Adora's never fully figured out the real relationship between Glimmer and Weaver, for example. And how did Bow end up a part of this? He's the sweetest guy but is that real? Or just a front to hide his true nature?

Okay, maybe being in Weaver's house has made her a little paranoid. Someone's making people disappear though so Adora's

allowed to be a little wary. Catra would call her a dummy for just trusting everyone.

"She's here because she was tricked. Like all of us," Adora replies. "I think if anyone's suspicious, it's Scorpia. She lives here. Shouldn't she know this place inside and out? Including the code to the gate and how to find the circuit breaker?"

Glimmer frowns. "Yeah, that is strange. What else is weird about her?"

"Well, she keeps trying to separate Catra from the group."

"Arhghg!" Glimmer yells, a jumble of sounds and rage. "You're just jealous! I thought you had actually figured something out but you're just pissed that Catra wants to spend time with someone else besides you."

"Doesn't really seem like she has a choice," Adora mumbles back.

Glimmer opens her mouth but is cut off by Bow. "There's nothing here. How about we go back to the sitting room, light a fire, and wait for everyone else there?"

It's a disaster. Someone's left wood out – probably *Scorpia*, Adora thinks with a sneer, cause she's so muscular and *helpful* – but none of them know how to build a fire. They open the curtains so that the moonlight can give them a bit of illumination but it's not nearly enough to truly see.

"You have to open the flue," Bow offers.

"Great. Now what the hell is that?" Glimmer asks. She usually has staff for this.

Adora's childhood home certainly didn't have a fireplace. It barely had working heat most of the time.

She knows to remove the screen at least. Glimmer refuses to pick up any logs so Adora makes quick work of that, stacking them

neatly into the fireplace. There's no matches. No lighter.

"Maybe I could find some newspaper, light it, and bring it over," Adora suggests.

"There's mysterious 'accidents' happening to everyone. You really wanna chance it?" Glimmer asks. She picks up a poker and begins angrily jabbing at the logs.

Bow walks a bit closer. His eyes are soft and the fact that Glimmer still can't see how he feels about her is pretty ridiculous.

"Here, let's make sure the vents are open and then we can go in search of something to light it," he suggests.

Stubbornly, Glimmer continues to poke around, grumbling to herself. "Gorgeous idiot," is all Adora can make out among the sound of the wood being pushed around aimlessly.

Glimmer hits another log. And then another. And then she must miss because the next sound that Adora hears in the near-dark is metal hitting metal. Something clicks.

Even standing four feet away, she feels the ground under them shift.

The area in front of the fireplace, the metal hearth inches away from Glimmer's toes, creaks loudly before it recesses. It lowers just enough that when it slides under the grate holding the logs, it completely disappears from sight.

Below, all Adora can see is a dark pit, large enough for a person to fall right into. A second too late, she realizes that that's what's happening. Glimmer's frozen in confusion, still leaning forward to poke at the wood. Her balance is thrown off now. Almost in slow-motion, Adora watches Glimmer sway, try to catch herself, and sway again. She tilts forward towards the dark abyss precariously.

Adora lunges towards her but she's just too far away. Bow's there in an instant, yelling out for Glimmer. He doesn't even seem to

think about it. He just screams, his deep voice echoing in the cavernous room. And he dives. Bow throws his body to the ground – or where the ground should be – and uses his left hand to blindly push Glimmer back.

He catches her right in the stomach. The air escapes her lungs in a loud huff as she falls back away from the pit, barreling down to land on her ass.

The trajectory of Bow's body continues on though. Adora catches the look on his face right as he seems to realize there's no way of getting out of this. His big friendly chocolate brown eyes fill with worry and fear. Glimmer grasps for his hand but it's already too late.

Bow falls shoulder first into the open pit, the rest of his body following until he disappears from sight.

"Noo!" Glimmer screams.

Adora dives to grab at his ankles but whiffs it. As soon as he's gone, the hearth slides back out, locking back into place with an ominous click.

Catra's lighting every candelabra she can find in the place when they hear the scream. One second, she's on her tiptoes trying to use her zippo to reach a thick iron candelabra in the hall and hoping that igniting these candles doesn't summon the Sanderson Sisters or something, and the next, they're rushing off towards Adora and Glimmer's voices.

They find the two of them in the sitting room, scratching desperately at the floor around the fireplace.

"What happened?" Scorpia asks.

"Bow's gone!" Glimmer shouts back. Her face is stained with tears.

Adora doesn't even look up at them, too busy trying to pull at pieces of the chimney. "He's in here somewhere."

"In the floor?" DT tries to clarify.

Adora pauses to turn to them. She has to pull up her phone to shine a light.

"Where's Entrapta?" she asks.

"Disappeared into a sealed room," Catra explains.

No matter how many times she turns it over in her head, it still sounds ridiculous. Entrapta's stuck behind a door that looks like it hasn't been opened in half a century. Scorpia tried to convince Catra it wasn't possible, but they both know that literally anything can happen inside that house.

It's all her fault that Entrapta's missing. If Catra hadn't convinced her that her theory was probably correct, the weirdo wouldn't have been chasing leads all over the place. All they had to do was stick together and yet, Catra let 'Trapta go wandering off all by herself.

Fuck. Half their group has already disappeared. Any of them could be next.

Adora sits back onto her heels, slumping in defeat.

"This isn't working," she announces. Her voice is dark, hollow. Like the reality of how much they definitely don't know is catching up to her.

"Well, try poking it again," Glimmer suggests. She's not slowing down at attempting to save Arrows.

"No, I mean. We're on the defensive. Maybe we should start fighting back." Adora turns to the rest of the group for support.

"I don't know about you, Blondie, but I like to *know* what I'm actually fighting *against,"* DT replies.

"It's the mansion!" Glimmer yells. "This place is fucking haunted."

Catra has to ignore how her fur raises on its ends. There are certain... *words* …that she avoids using to describe the house if possible. The 'h' word is a big one.

"It's just an old place," Catra argues. "Don't be ridiculous. *Hordak* is the person actually pulling the strings. He probably set up all this and he's watching us run around like idiots."

"An hour ago you thought it was Mermista," Glimmer points out. "Now you're certain it's Hordak? What about when the rest of us go missing? You just gonna blame it all on us?!"

Catra smirks, trying to project a confidence that is rapidly dwindling. "Not all of you. Just you, Sparkles. Scorpia's too nice. Adora isn't a good enough liar. And DT wouldn't have made half their audience disappear."

DT places both hands over their heart. "Aw," they say facetiously. "You really do get me, Kitten."

"I think this is all bullshit so no one will suspect you!" Glimmer yells back. "In order to pull this off, someone would have to know the mansion, be in all of our heads, and get off on torturing people. That's literally only you!"

Inside, Catra *burns.* It's a weird anger, the irrational and inextinguishable kind she hasn't felt since she was a kid. All this fucking rage and nothing to do with it. It climbs out of the pit of her belly, up her throat, and threatens to jump out of her mouth, until Catra grits her teeth to shut it in.

She's never hurt a fucking fly. People take one look at her clothes and her claws and think she's just Fright Zone trash. Everything in Glimmer's tone is dripping with judgment. Like she's so much *better* than Catra. Like she's more deserving of Adora's time.

Catra feels her claws descend. Even in the dark, Glimmer catches sight of them and falls back a step, right onto her butt. She doesn't look sorry exactly but she seems to regret making the accusation so blatant maybe.

Adora rises to her feet to jump into Catra's line of vision. It's almost enough to make Catra look away from the gremlin on the floor.

"Hey," Adora says softly. "Let's go take a walk."

Glimmer frowns and that moment of remorse has vanished. "Adora, did you just hear a word I said? And now you want to go off with her alone?" Her voice so fucking incredulous.

Behind her, Catra feels Scorpia move closer. "Gosh, I think Glimmer's right, Adora. Maybe Catra and I should actually be the ones to step outside for a breather."

Adora doesn't even look away from Catra's eyes. "I've got it. Thanks though." Her face is pinched, just a little.

It sounds like Scorpia winces. "Gotta disagree with you there, Adora. It's been a long time and you and Catra don't know each other as well as you used to. So we'll go grab some of her favorite tea and you and Glimmer can keep trying to unlock the floor or whatever so your friend comes back."

As soon as Scorpia's pincer outstretches towards Catra, Adora juts forward.

"Cat, what do *you* need?" she asks.

The answer makes Catra all squirmy. Glimmer's shooting daggers with her eyes, Scorpia's radiating anxiety, and DT's attention is pinging back and forth between the four of them. Catra's fucking livid and, whether she wants to admit it or not, fucking terrified. And...

All Catra needs is Adora.

She motions with her head towards the door. “Come on.”

Scorpia’s pincer drops slowly.

“Adora,” Glimmer groans. “We have to keep looking for Bow.”

“We need to regroup and come up with a plan. Me and Catra are just gonna check in quickly. Can the three of you gather some weapons? There’s probably stuff around here that can help us defend ourselves. Like Bow had suggested.”

“Catra’s got knives for fingers. How are we supposed to stop her when she turns on us?” Glimmer asks.

Adora squares her shoulders to turn back to her friend. “I don’t know why the two of you never gelled but we’re all in this together now. I suggest you squash whatever beef you have.”

DT makes a clucking sound to themself. “Really, Adora? You seem like a smart girl. You can't think of *any* reason Catra and Glimmer might not like each other?”

“Well, Glimmer-” Scorpia begins, only to be cut off by DT.

“And Scorpia,” they say, “I’ve never seen you have such a strong reaction to anyone before. What is it about Adora that makes you go from cuddly teddy bear to rottweiler?”

Scorpia begins sputtering, apparently incapable of words now.

“She’s just being a good friend,” Catra says. “Not that you’d be familiar with the concept.”

“Friend?” DT repeats. They smile slowly so that she can see all of their sharp, pointy white teeth. “Well, I guess the rest of us will just let you and Adora go get *friendly* with each other. All alone. Unless Glimmer and Scorpia have some reason to object?”

Catra spins to Scorpia, silently warning her not to say anything more. Adora keeps her eyes on Glimmer.

After a long beat, Sparkles picks up the poker again and goes back to jabbing at the hearth. She grunts as she works out her frustration on the defenseless fireplace.

Adora quickly grabs Catra's hand and leads her from the room.

"Hmm," DT hums, as they watch Catra and Adora go. "Be safe."

She doesn't really want to leave them alone with the other two – who knows what DT will convince them of once they're gone – but the air is getting too thin in that room. Too stifled with a lot of unsaid shit that they don't have time for right now. Best to just cool off and figure out how to get out of there.

Adora pulls her to the hallway outside of the library. She's still got her serious face on. Catra's stomach twists, worried that Adora will try to talk about feelings for the first time in their life-long friendship.

Instead, Adora pushes Catra against the hall and stops only a couple inches away.

"You know you can trust me, right?"

"Duh," Catra answers automatically.

"One of those people is lying. I don't want to think it's Glimmer. But all I know is you're the one person I actually trust."

Catra tries to ignore that Adora – *her* Adora – is declaring her loyalty while standing close enough that she can feel the blonde's breath ghosting across her skin. Realistically, Catra thinks they're *all* lying. Just maybe not about being responsible for trapping a group of people here and picking them off one by one.

"So what's the play?" she asks.

Adora sets her lips into a hard line but even in the dark, her eyes light up just a bit.

"We get back in there and keep everyone close. Make sure no one is out of our sight again tonight. We keep each other even closer though. Watch each other's backs."

"That makes sense," Catra says, trying to play it cool. "We keep each other safe."

"Yeah. And if there *is* money, you're the only one I want to split it with. It's not like Glimmer needs it anyway."

Catra feels her tail fluff out in warning. "The money? That's all you care about?"

Adora takes a step forward to try to see Catra better in the low light. That just puts her too far into Catra's personal space. It's confusing and annoying. She feels dumb – she'd thought Adora wanted to get her alone to reassure her after Glimmer's shitty behavior.

But she's the same old Adora. Giant head still trying to figure out how to work all the angles and win. It's the same attitude that led to her getting first place in their stupid 8th grade pumpkin carving contest. Adora made a log of the winners every year in middle school so that when it was their turn, she'd have the perfect formula. Catra just wanted to carve a hot lady wearing a bikini and riding a motorcycle. Adora had insisted that the design had to be popular, relevant, a little nostalgic to please the teachers, and *wholesome*. She used a stencil she printed on the library computer to trace some boring family movie series with a dog, which was probably cheating but whatever. Catra always did go along with her worst ideas.

Arching an eyebrow, Adora tilts her head. "Well, no, obviously. I-I want to spend time with you." When Catra doesn't respond, still trying to figure out the angle, Adora continues, "I thought you'd want that too. I know you never reached out but I thought we were still friends. Was that completely stupid of me?"

"No!" Catra says quickly. "We're friends. You just...were busy. School and stuff. I didn't want to distract you."

Weaver might have not-so-subtly pointed out a few dozen times, always after a bottle of wine of course, that Adora needed to focus on her dreams. Not on her loser best friend.

"You're never a distraction, Cat. For so long, you were the only person who believed me when I said I'd get out of here."

Her big blue eyes look on the verge of tears and Catra has to force herself to look away, feeling her own bottom lip start to quiver.

"Of course. You're too much of a stubborn asshole to ever give up on anything."

Adora scoffs quietly. "Wonder who I picked that up from."

She pokes Catra in the ribs, earning a quiet squeak that has her blushing under her fur.

"No matter what happens, can we promise that we're not gonna lose each other again? Bright Moon isn't *that* far away."

"Somehow I don't imagine Sparkles is gonna be too happy about me dropping in to hang out," Catra mumbles.

Adora sighs. "Seriously, though – you okay, Cat? Glimmer is being a fucking nightmare. I don't get what her problem is."

Catra just shakes her head. She can't really blame Sparkles. Adora probably struts around the apartment in her skimpy little workout clothes without even realizing she's torturing the poor bastard to death. Now, Glimmer has to watch Adora rush around defending the only person who's got even more experience pining after the oblivious idiot.

"I'm fine, dummy. After this is all over, I'm sure you'll force me to have some corny-ass sleepover where we braid each other's hair

and talk about everything we've missed and eat junk until you puke."

"Ooh," Adora says suddenly, bouncing on her toes. To Catra's amusement, she reaches into her pocket and pulls out two off-brand chocolate bars. "I stole these for you. Your favorite."

"No one's favorite is the supermarket brand," Catra replies. She rolls her eyes to distract Adora from the smile on her face, before snatching one of the candy bars out of her hand. "Split 'em with me."

Adora nods quickly. They unwrap the candy and take a bite, still standing way too close. Catra tries to take a cute bite, not breaking eye contact. She lowers her head to look up through her lashes and everything. Adora just shoves the entire bar into her face in two big pieces.

"When we win that inheritance, I'll buy you all the name brand candy you want," Adora promises around a mouth full of chocolate.

Catra makes a face. She doesn't know what she's expecting. If this goober actually picked up on her (admittedly subtle) signals, Catra would probably just have a full freakout anyway.

Adora must misread the signs, unsurprisingly, cause she looks like she regrets her words immediately.

"I think the two of us have a good chance of gaining it if we work together. Is that not what you were thinking?" Adora asks. "I know you and Entrapta had some kind of secret plan. If this *is* all a game, you're still playing, Cat. A few sides, even."

Her tone isn't unkind exactly but the accusation, and the truth of it, makes Catra bristle. Maybe it was too much to hope that she'd win a bunch of money, crack some 100-year-old secrets, and get out of this with enough money to set her up for a long while. No more working for creeps like Weaver. Hordak had already reached out with an offer for her to come join his business and, since that

dude is a literal zombie, it wasn't something Catra was looking forward to. Options were limited though.

"Okay, princess," Catra breaths out. "We'll do this your way then."

There's a cute blush crawling up Adora's neck. "Haven't heard that name in a while."

"Don't worry, Princess Adora. I'll be your knight," Catra calls out softly, trying to mimic the wheezy voice she had as a kitten, when she chased imaginary monsters around the yard to protect Adora. Of course, even as a princess, the dummy insisted on carrying her own sword and fighting for *Catra's* honor.

The thought of a sword jogs Catra's memory. Stuffing the rest of her candy in her pocket and hoping that she doesn't regret this later when it's a melted mess, Catra breezes past Adora and rushes into the library.

"What's up?" Adora calls after her.

Catra shushes her as she glances around the room. The library's a completely useless fucking room. Weaver never once went in there but they were forbidden from playing in it when they were kids. There was nothing really interesting inside anyway – it was mostly super old books, a couple globes that were outdated – except two items that Adora never could keep her eyes off of.

She finds them on a back wall, still hanging between two dusty bookcases. A few feet above eye-level are two swords, propped up so that they're crossing each other. Adora was always drawn to the fancier one in the back, with its gold hilt and giant pearl or whatever. Catra had a preference for the larger, silver one, particularly the way it flared out on the way towards the brown leather-wrapped handle. Like it could do some nasty damage if needed.

She hears Adora catch up quickly.

"They're still here?" she asks, voice full of wonder.

“Yeah. And we can finally actually reach them,” Catra replies. She jumps up to pull the sword down and completely fucking whiffs it. Her hand barely reaches the end of the blade.

Adora laughs as Catra takes a couple steps back before taking another jumping leap. She at least reaches mid-way now but rethinks grabbing a giant knife by the sharpest part.

“Aw, it’s okay, little buddy. You’re probably still growing,” Adora chuckles.

Catra shuts her right up by launching her body at the blonde. Adora yelps as Catra scales her like a tree. (Mind you, not really the way Catra had always fantasized about doing that but whatever.) She has to dig her feet into Adora’s sides and push on her shoulders to vault herself up.

Adora has no balance on a good day. With another person wrapping their legs around her neck and a tail flopping into her face, she keeps careening wildly from side to side, leaving Catra to have to hang on for dear life.

“Stop squirming,” Catra grunts out.

“There’s a *much* taller bookshelf right there!”

Catra doesn’t bother answering. She snatches Adora’s ponytail to the right, trying to use it like reins.

“Cut that out!”

“Mush, puppy!”

“I hate you,” Adora grumbles but she walks back closer to the swords.

Convinced they’re steady enough, Catra pops up so that her feet are on Adora’s shoulders. The blonde grunts but she imagines it’s just for show. Adora literally threw that armoire in her room to the side and Catra’s pretty sure she weighs a lot less than that.

The thought that Adora could throw her around makes Catra unconsciously trill quietly.

“Did you get them?” Adora asks impatiently.

“What? You getting tired?”

“I could do this all night!” Adora swears but she does sound a little winded.

Up close, both swords look even more dangerous and badass than Catra remembers them being. They’re still razor sharp, the edge glinting in a menacing way. If anyone’s planning on fucking with her and Adora, this will definitely scare them off.

The swords are held up by what looks like just a couple of rusty nails below the hilts and one further down to keep them at an angle. Catra plucks the top blade off the wall and drops it below on the ground, making sure to miss Adora by a couple inches.

It doesn’t matter. When the weapon loudly clatters against the wood floor, Adora jumps almost a foot in the air like she isn’t carrying Catra’s full weight precariously.

“Hey,” she yells up. “Sword safety!!”

Adora swivels again while Catra tries to hook her claws into the wall to avoid falling.

“Keep it steady down there!”

“Maybe I should be the one sitting on *your* face then!” Adora yells out.

Catra freezes. For one, she’s *standing* so that’s ridiculous. But also. Her brain kinda just shuts down as it turns those words over again and again. Adora, from what she can tell, is fidgeting like she has to go to the bathroom.

“I didn’t-....I mean...Not that I-uh…”

Taking a deep breath to swallow all the *gay gay gaygaygay* back down into her body, Catra reaches for the other sword.

"Relax, dummy," she sighs out, clearly talking to *both* of them. "I know you didn't mean anything by it."

Adora laughs nervously, all too high-pitched. "Right…"

Catra saves them from this unbearably awkward situation by tugging on the remaining sword. It doesn't move an inch. She pulls again, this time with a lot more force.

"Need a hand up there?"

She's about to lob back, 'thought you *didn't* want to sit on my face?' when there's a loud creak from the sword. It still doesn't detach entirely, just pulls back from the wall a foot and then retracts back into place.

"What the fuck?"

"What's wrong, Cat?"

"It's like a crank or someth-"

Catra's cut off by a crash from another room, so loud it echoes into the library and makes the walls shake. A cacophony of breaking glass and screeching metal, it's sickening enough to make Catra's blood run cold.

She hops down from Adora's shoulders and lands on the floor next to her. The blonde's eyes are wide and terrified. Guilty. Like the day that Catra broke Weaver's window and started the chain reaction that brought them all into this mess.

Adora wants to go be the hero and own up to whatever horror they just caused. Catra shakes her head vehemently.

"No way. That was *not* my fault!"

Adora takes off running out of the room before she's barely done with the sentence.

She comes into the foyer with such a head of steam that she almost crashes right into Scorpia. Adora's sure Catra's behind her somewhere, since she was always faster. But she has that unsettling ability to move almost silently whenever she needs to.

In front of her, Scorpia, Glimmer, and DT are all gathered around the wreckage of what used to be the chandelier hanging as the centerpiece of the room.

The bronze arms are all bent and damaged, resembling a beached octopus. Rows and rows of shattered baubles lay scattered all over the floor. The fake candles, which Catra used to joke served no purpose except looking stupid and rich, have died out, most of them cracked. There's even dents in the floor from the impact.

"What the fuck happened here?" Catra yells, appearing abruptly behind Adora. Her voice is almost convincing, but Catra was always pretty good at lying to herself.

The other three look dazed. They're all catching their breath, Scorpia even clutching her chest. Adora's never personally been close enough to immediate peril to experience that sensation of your life flashing before your life. But these three look like they've seen some *shit.*

Scorpia blinks twice slowly, before shaking her head. A bit of glass falls off of her shoulder.

"It...fell," she says dumbly. "We were right there and it just...fell right out of the sky."

"Hell of an aim it had," DT remarks. They cut their eyes towards Catra, now so close to Adora that she can almost feel the fabric of that sweater brushing against her arm. "Where were you two?"

Adora asks instead, “It just came down for no reason? Scorpia, it hasn't been loose or anything when you’ve cleaned it lately?”

Scorpia frowns. “No. I’d notice something like that. Ms. Weaver would *never* let me be careless. I know I’m kinda a klutz sometimes but no ma’am, she did not stand for that. Let me tell ya.”

Adora’s eyes zero in on Glimmer, who’s quiet for the first time in...probably ever. “Are you all okay? Why don't we just go take a seat? I’ll make you some tea. Scorpia, maybe you’ll have a better chance with getting a fire started.”

Adora moves to head to the kitchen. If anyone sees her face, she feels like the guilt will be loud and clear. She’s not even sure she and Catra did anything wrong. It could just be two totally unrelated events. What kind of psychopath sets up a hidden lever to release a giant chandelier.

Well, Weaver, probably. But-

“We were only there for a minute,” Glimmer mutters to herself. “We were in the sitting room. Scorpia suggested we follow your advice and go search for something to defend ourselves. We came out here and it was just for a *minute.* That’s not a coincidence.”

Adora feels Catra grab ahold of her arm, gripping her bicep tightly.

Glimmer’s eyes turn to the two of them slowly. “Where were you?” she asks, repeating DT’s question.

“Just talking in the hall,” Adora answers.

DT side steps some debris to move closer to them. “The whole time? You were gone for quite a while.”

Scorpia looks between the four of them, clearly confused and probably still in shock.

“We were in the library for a minute,” Catra admits.

When that doesn't seem to spark anything for Scorpia, who theoretically knows the place inside and out, Adora's sure that the sword and the chandelier actually were just a coincidence.

"Plotting to knock off the rest of us?" DT asks.

Adora feels goosebumps raise all over her skin. No such luck convincing herself they're completely innocent apparently. Catra uses her hold on Adora's arm to pull the blonde back, placing herself defensively at the front.

DT points at the chandelier. "It didn't swing. Didn't weave back and forth like a wire being slowly severed. It just dropped like an inelegant stone. A clean cut."

With a frown, Glimmer leans closer down to it. "They're right. This chain link isn't rusted or anything. It's clipped in half. What the hell would be strong enough to do that in one go without us noticing?"

"I'm sure Catra and Adora can tell us," DT says.

Scorpia finally snaps out of it, moving closer to defend Catra. "Now, let's hold up here for a minute. I think we're all just scared. And-and sleep-deprived! It's getting real late. We're just a little stressed."

"A little stressed?" Glimmer repeats. "We've all witnessed horrible things and someone just tried to kill us. Why does everyone keep trying to explain this away like *ration* exists here anymore?!"

DT shifts closer again. The move puts them near one of the lit candelabras on the wall. The flame highlights their sharp features in a way that makes them look like an ancient statue of a god. Polished, crafty, shrewd.

They don't take their eyes off of Adora, like they think she's the one who's most likely to break under scrutiny.

“Maybe the two of you are working together,” DT suggests. “Maybe you have been this whole time. You led us away so someone could attack Mermista. Adora let Kyle disappear. You were together when Lonnie went missing. And each one of you had a member of your group get snatched at the exact same time. Everywhere you go, something bad follows.”

“It’s a *house,* DT. Not like there’s much room for us to spread out,” Catra says. “One of you was also there for every one of those incidents. What puts you above suspicion?”

“Because someone just tried to murder *us* with a fucking light fixture. Besides, you two need the money the most. I heard Weaver bragging about how Adora was starting med school soon. That’s not cheap. And Kitten, I know you don’t have any other options. Money makes people desperate.”

Scorpia shakes her head so intensely that her whole upper body moves from side to side. “That’s not gonna work, buddy. I know Wildcat cares about me. She would never hurt me.”

Glimmer huffs. “Maybe she’s not trying to hurt you. Maybe she was just trying to scare us off.” She turns to point at Catra. “I *know* you’re in on this. You were always more under Weaver’s thumb than you want to admit.”

“We had a strictly professional relationship,” Catra says, clearly trying to kill all of the emotion in her voice. Her claws accidentally dig in where they’re wrapped around Adora’s arm. “You’re the one who tried to get the old bat to be your new mom, not me.”

Glimmer growls. Genuinely straight up *growls,* a sound that Adora had previously only ever associated with Catra. When Glimmer’s eyes blaze just a bit more purple, Catra takes a step back, pushing Adora even further behind her.

“You always had more power than her,” Catra says. “That’s why she had nothing to teach you. You didn’t need her and Weaver

fucking hated it. You never let her control you – you just gonna stand there and let DT do it to you now?"

That takes all the wind out of Glimmer's sails. For as easy as she is to escalate, particularly tonight, she's generally able to let it go soon. At least, outwardly, cause Adora knows Glimmer's been stewing in her distrust of Catra for half a decade now.

Glimmer pauses and looks genuinely annoyed at herself. "Gods, I hate it here. Something in this house always makes me act like I'm out of my fucking mind. This whole place is cursed."

"Well, let's chill the fuck out, secure this bag, and we'll never have to return," Catra tells her.

Scorpia turns quickly back to Catra, so fast that her tail swings out behind her and nearly rams into the decimated chandelier.

"Never return?" she questions. She swallows loud enough for Adora to hear it. Then Scorpia's lower lip flops open, her face a mask of confusion and slow realization. "I know you didn't really love it here, Wildcat. But I thought you might want to stick around? Continue all the important work you and Weaver had been doing? Making natural medicine for folks? Maybe I could even help you?"

Catra heaves a pointed, sharp laugh. "Important work? Is that what she told you? I spent years breathing in chemicals with no fucking ventilation so we could make spanish fly and knock-off poppers to sell to gas stations and sex shops. Fake herbal remedies and tinctures for the rubes at New Age stores." She ignores Scorpia's frown to continue. "I'm not a nice person who was helping Weaver make people healthy, Scorp. I'm gonna get my money and I'm getting out of here. You should do the same."

Scorpia opens her mouth to reply but she's cut off by Adora's own disbelieving laugh. "That's all this ever was? Just a grift?"

"Gotta respect the old lady," Catra says. "She committed hard. Really leaned into the whole supernatural sorceress vibe."

Adora scoffs at Catra's misplaced admiration. "Okay, I'm done playing. We go everywhere as a group now. Let's all go make some coffee and then we can just park ourselves in the sitting room and wait for Hordak to return."

Glimmer agrees easily. DT's wheels are turning, probably trying to come up with their next move, but they eventually nod.

Catra moves to head out, sliding her grip along Adora's arm until they're hand in hand again.

"Actually," Scorpia says, sounding strangled. "I think I'm gonna try it alone from now on."

Catra barely glances back, almost like she isn't taking this seriously. "Don't be an i-"

"No, Wil-... *Catra*," Scorpia interrupts. "I've got a lot to...think about. I'm just gonna wait in my room til morning."

She takes off down the hall quickly. Catra looks as if she might follow but some protective part of Adora makes her grip their joined hands more tightly.

"We have to stick together," she reminds Catra. There's something churning in her stomach that almost feels like guilt. It's odd – Adora hasn't done anything wrong, not exactly. She's not responsible for whatever turmoil Scorpia seems to be in or her decision to separate from everyone else. And yet, Adora can't help feeling at least a little bad for the other girl.

Glimmer shuffles behind them, her feet lightly stepping on some of the glass.

"Come on," she says as she pushes past the two of them. "Coffee definitely sounds like what we all need."

"Yes," DT agrees, following her. "Miles to go before we sleep and all that."

Catra sighs, still looking after Scorpia. Adora meets her eyes and sees that same ungrounded guilt echoed back at her.

The way that Miss Weaver talked about Adora, Scorpia expected her to be nicer maybe. More willing to listen. Not this weird alpha energy she keeps trying to project.

Catra's always gushed about her – or as much as Catra could gush about someone, accidentally letting little details about their adventures or how smart or how resourceful Adora was when they were friends slip out when she's had a couple beers.

'When they were friends'. Past tense, Scorpia thinks. It was supposed to all be in the past. It was supposed to be something that wouldn't come up for Catra anymore, her misguided feeling that Adora would want to be around her again. Catra was still living at the same house and Adora hadn't been by *once* since she graduated. What kind of friend does that?

They're much closer than friends, that much is obvious. Weaver had hinted that whatever Catra felt before for Adora, she now looked the same way at Scorpia. But that was probably just another lie for the lady of the house to laugh about behind their backs. To keep Scorpia there and complacent after she casually mentioned that maybe a raise and some slightly better treatment could be found at another gig.

Scorpia loves this house. Some of her best childhood memories are from the few times she got to visit her mother at work and explore the mansion, talking to the spirits, finding mysteries in the crawlspaces. Weaver always ordered for her to be kept out of sight, of course. But Scorpia never minded. Obedience and open-mindedness are some of her best qualities.

That's probably why she's the only one who truly understands this house. Catra's wrong about that – this place isn't what she thinks it is at all. *Weaver* isn't who Catra thinks she was. She was cold

and calculating but she was also fragile and...sad. They’re actually a lot more alike than Catra ever wants to admit.

There’s just something about this whole fiasco that doesn’t feel like Weaver’s kind of game. She would have made it more personal, maybe? A long, sprawling video about how right she was always. A vague indecipherable warning to each of them. Tailored temptations to make them all prove their worthiness for the inheritance. Heck, Weaver made Scorpia jump through more hoops than this just to collect her annual holiday bonus!

The good news is that Scorpia still has a plan. She's been friends with Catra long enough to learn that you always need an exit strategy. So instead of staying in her room as she said, Scorpia waits until she's sure that no one is coming to check on her, which *sure,* she thought for a second that *maybe* Catra would remember all the good times they had and at least want to check that she's okay but nope. Adora's here now and Scorpia's old news. Those two, they're in a room together and everyone else might as well not even exist. Digression! Wildcat’s not coming – no one is – so Scorpia uses this chance to sneak out to the small passage behind her room, heading straight for her favorite place in the house.

After she hit that growth spurt, it got much more difficult to scooch through these narrow halls. But Scorpia’s a lot more nimble than anyone gives her credit for. She only sorta has accidentally damaged the frames of two or three of the tiniest hidden spaces.

She follows the familiar route, mentally making a note to come back later and finally do some tidying up in here. Just because it's a creepy crawl space doesn't mean it can't be clean and cheerful!

Scorpia stumbles lightly as she exits into the hall, climbing out from behind a large floor mirror that no one's ever questioned the uselessness of. She turns to head out onto the patio on this side of the house when something catches her eye.

That odd door tucked into the corner of the reading nook. The one Scorpia’s never been able to get open, on account of Miss Weaver saying that it didn't exist and even if it did, she wouldn't have the key, because it definitely *did not* exist. There's lights coming from under it. Not like a lamp or anything that she would expect. It's the glow from a TV or a computer monitor.

As quietly as she can, she tiptoes over, tail ready just in case. If this is all a misunderstanding, she'll probably feel awful for stinging an innocent person. But you can't be too careful right now. That Adora's still wandering around and who knows what she's up to.

With a deep breath, Scorpia places her pincer on the knob and tries to wrench the door open to catch whoever's inside by surprise. It doesn't budge.

“Ugh! Not again,” she whispers.

She steps back to check the door, make sure it isn't some sealed illusion like the one that took Entrapta.

She's so focused on the door that she doesn't notice there's anyone behind her until the rag is placed over her mouth and nose. Scorpia tries to struggle but this person is *strong*, like really weirdly strong. The arm not holding the rag is wrapped tightly around her waist, trapping her tail between their bodies.

Scorpia attempts to hold her breath, the rag smelling of chemicals. Familiar chemicals. But she's panicked and alone and after a couple of big gulping breaths, her vision begins to tunnel. Her limbs grow heavy. She cries out one last time, hoping against hope that Catra will hear, but as her body begins to go slack, the door in front of her opens and Scorpia is pulled inside.

Chapter End Notes

> i was listening to the over the garden wall soundtrack while editing but it got too creepy so i switched to schmigadoon, which is just completely the wrong vibe but fun.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> thanks for following me on this creepy journey! today, it comes to a conclusion.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra hadn't meant to be rude to Scorpia. The big dummy was probably the most genuinely sweet person she knew, even if Scorpia had never heard of the concept of boundaries. But Catra was feeling a little irked that Scorpia still held some completely unfounded belief that Catra was good in any way. Especially after Catra had almost just killed her by accident and inspired Adora to lie about it.

Any of those words – literally any of them – would have been reasonable to say. So instead, Catra acted like a bit of a jerk and Scorpia took off.

It's not hard to convince Glimmer to ditch the idea of coffee and instead go searching for Scorpia. Obviously, she'd prefer as many buffers between Catra and Adora as possible. DT doesn't say shit. Who knows what fucking scheme they're spinning in their head.

Adora, who Catra once watched rescue and bottle feed a puppy, thinks Scorpia will be fine and should just fuck right off.

"That's *not* what I said," Adora huffs as she follows Catra to the bottom of the basement stairs.

"That's what your face said," Catra argues.

"She left on her own. Why are you trying to follow her?"

"If you did the same, I'd follow you."

“That’s...different,” Adora says slowly. “I-we’ve known each other forever. And I don’t play games like that. Running away just so someone will chase me.”

“Neither does Scorpia,” Catra tells her. “I swear I heard her yell for help.”

“Which means we should be going in the *opposite* direction of wherever she went,” DT interjects. “I don’t want to be the obvious one, but unfortunately, you’re forcing me into this role – someone’s after us. We should be heading *away* from danger.”

“I agree,” Adora grumbles.

“Scorpia’s nice. And she’s our best chance of making it out of here,” Glimmer says. “With her knowledge of the place. And those muscles.”

It sounds like Adora harrumphs. And since Catra is in the middle of trying to do one nice thing, she lets herself step on the dummy’s toe. Just as a warning. Adora looks horribly offended but at least she shuts up.

“We already checked down here,” DT points out.

“When we were looking for the circuit breaker. Hopefully, Scorp will be easier to find and in better shape.”

Catra leads them towards the right. She's certain she heard Scorpia while they were upstairs but through a whole floor, it's hard to make out where the sound came from. Instincts say it's this way. Common sense agrees with DT that they should probably find the smallest room in the house and barricade all the entrances until help comes.

She continues on anyway. Scorpia deserves it. If it weren't for her relentless optimism, Catra wouldn't have the small circle of almost-friends she has now. After Adora, she was content to be alone forever. Scorpia wasn't having that at all and learning how to let people in just a sliver made Catra comfortable enough to at

least be semi-cool with Entrapta, Lonnie, and Mermista. Even DT, who is pretty okay when they aren't being the absolute worst.

Like now.

“If we find Scorpia wearing a Weaver wig and speaking in her voice, no one will be surprised, right?” DT asks.

When they don’t get a response, they quietly click their tongue to themselves.

“Glimmer-”

“No, thank you,” she quickly interrupts.

“Oh, so short now? You were so talkative earlier when Adora and Catra were having their moment together.”

Catra reaches the first door and throws it open with a loud bang just to scare them a little. It works, just on Sparkles, who's not the intended target for once. But after she glimpses inside and her pink little face pales, Catra realizes the girl's more worried about that particular room than she is about her annoying guide.

Glimmer doesn't cross the threshold into Weaver's lab. She won't. As Catra and DT enter, Glimmer's toes touch the air around the doorframe and freeze so quickly that her upper half almost tips over.

“You okay?” Adora asks her, also hesitating at the entrance. Even from a few feet away, Catra can see the goosebumps on her skin.

“Yeah,” Glimmer replies. Catra half expects more than that but Sparkles shuts her mouth quickly. Her eyes dart around the room.

Adora cautiously takes a couple more steps inside. “It hasn't changed at all.”

“Most of this stuff is harmless. But it's probably best not to touch anything. Just in case,” Catra tells them.

“Harmless?” Glimmer repeats with a scoff. “Belladonna, oleander, castor beans.”

“Yes, Kitten. Why don't you try out a few things to prove it?” DT smirks at her. They're barely looking for Scorpia, not even bothering to bend down to check for any sign of her under the table next to them.

Catra does a quick but thorough look of the place. Nothing seems disturbed, if you completely ignore the general *disturbing* atmosphere of the room. The air that's gross enough to induce nausea. The smell of chemicals and alcohol and herbs that scream ‘warning!’

She takes them out swiftly. The next door is locked so that's a bust. DT reaches for the knob across the hall before Catra can alert them that it's one of the sealed rooms.

No one really sees it. DT’s got their phone in their hand but they never have a chance to shine it into the room. Glimmer and Adora are just a step behind and Catra’s still occupied with the last door.

DT turns the knob and immediately takes a step forward.

And then disappears from sight, minus their thin green hand still clinging to the knob. The rest of their body gets enveloped by the dark abyss of the room. The door swings back and forth slightly with their weight.

Catra doesn’t even get to appreciate the uncharacteristic way that DT’s voice changes as they shout, all that fake bravado gone.

“Ahh!” comes out sounding like a scared kid. It kinda reminds Catra of Kyle, actually. “Help?” The word goes up at the end and everything, more of a question than an assertive demand.

The other three all scramble closer. Adora practically dives onto the floor to be able to reach DT better, while Catra and Glimmer are a lot more wary when they approach.

The sight before them freezes both in their tracks.

The room doesn't have a fucking floor. Well, okay, it technically *does*, it's just a couple feet below floor-level. And covered in snakes. Literally, there's like two dozen snakes sliding around on the concrete of this dark, unfinished 4by 5-foot room, the size of a water closet.

Catra thinks about joking how this is a terrible use of space, especially during a housing crisis but smartly reads the vibe and resists.

"What the *fuck,* Weaver?" Glimmer hisses. "Why would anyone even need this?"

The snakes are all slender, a couple feet long. Red and black and yellow. Slithering languidly across each other.

DT flails as they struggle to continue to hang on. Their feet dangle only a couple of inches above the snakes. Unfortunately, the more they thrash about, the harder it seems to get to maintain their grip. And the more that the serpents below are starting to notice them.

Still laid out on the floor in the hall, Adora edges over closer with her hand outstretched. "Try to reach out. I'll grab you."

DT tries an arm but the door's open too wide for them to come anywhere near Adora. They kick out a long leg but even with the high heel, it doesn't come close. Their momentum pushes the door back a little further out of reach, as DT screams again.

"I *hate* snakes!"

"It's a pit of reptiles," Catra points out. "Shouldn't you feel right at home?"

"Let's throw you in a room of tigers and see if that fucking logic holds up!" they yell back.

Adora lets her hand fall to scoot in for a closer look. “It’s okay! It’s just king snakes. DT, you can drop down and we’ll be able to pull you up from the floor.”

Catra has to completely balk at that. “Those are coral snakes, dummy. They’re poisonous.”

“No, it’s king snakes. Remember the rhyme from girl scouts? If red touches yellow, you’re a safe fellow.”

“*Kills* a fellow,” Catra corrects. “DT, try to kick your legs out and swing back this way.”

They start doing just that immediately. It’s not very effective but Catra hopes it at least keeps their mind off of the impending danger.

“No, if red touches black, you’re dead, jack,” Adora argues back.

“This is why we got kicked out of girl scouts.”

“We got kicked out cause we tried to scam the cookie sales, Cat.”

“You’re both idiots!” Glimmer screams. “You’re risking someone’s life over a fucking rhyme you heard a decade ago.”

She notices one of the snakes trying to crawl up through the open doorway and, without a moment of hesitation, just punts it right back into the pit.

Begrudgingly, Catra has to admit that she’s kinda hot in a demented way.

“Glimmer’s right,” she says. “Let’s try to form a chain and grab ‘em.”

Wordlessly, Adora pushes herself further over the threshold of the doorway and Catra quickly jumps onto her back. She shimmies until her torso is resting on Adora’s shoulders and hopes that’s enough. When Glimmer doesn’t join them, Catra has to remind

herself that not everyone shares 15 years of history with them and instinctively knows how to leap into action.

Catra motions with her head. “Jump on.”

Tentatively, Glimmer crawls over both of them. Catra can feel how shaky she is, how unsure. She can hear Adora grunting to hold them both up. In the back of her mind, Catra knows they're not really stable enough to take on a 4th weight but there's nothing else they can do.

Right as Glimmer gets her legs onto Catra's hips, there's a quick movement below them.

And then it all happens both too fast to process and too slowly to look away from.

DT yelps in pain as the snake draws back from them. “Motherfucker!”

Their hand slips from the knob as they reach down for their leg without thinking. Their body hits the floor with a weird sound, both a thud and a squish for the poor snakes that don't make it out of the way in time.

Glimmer still reaches out but it's to grab at the door.

“Move!” she screams, as she pulls at it, jumping back into the hallway. Adora and Catra scramble after her.

The door slams shut just as another snake lunges at them. Adora pops back up onto her feet and is barreling down on Sparkles before Catra can even stop her.

“Why did you do that?!” she asks, raising her voice so loud that Glimmer almost seems to flinch.

“I was protecting the rest of us. There was nothing we could do for them.”

“You don’t know that!” Adora reaches for the door but Glimmer doesn’t move.

Catra pipes in with, “Can the two of you fight about this upstairs? We gotta get the hell out of this basement. Shit’s getting weird, even by Weaver’s standards. DT can probably figure it out – they were playing everyone.”

Adora shakes her nod. “I don’t think that’s true. Did you see how scared they were? They were as confused as the rest of us. Probably just lashing out cause they were afraid.” She holds her hand out towards the door again but Glimmer just pushes it away.

“Adora, you’re so kind. But you’re also pretty oblivious. I can’t believe I’m saying this, but I agree with Catra.”

Great. Catra turns to lead them back towards the stairwell. It sounds like Sparkles shoves Adora away from the door one last time before falling in step beside Catra.

With a sigh, Adora follows behind, dragging her feet loudly. “So they were just lying the whole time? I guess that makes sense. I couldn’t really believe what they were trying to say about Glimmer and Scorpia. I mean, Glimmer and I could never have feelings for each other.”

The air escapes Sparkles’ lungs loudly, almost like she’s been punched in the tit. Catra glances over to catch just as her face falls, seared with pain.

She hisses against her will and turns on Adora quickly, both of them stopping. Glimmer doesn’t even seem to notice, as her steps continue on.

“Shut up, dummy,” Catra whispers.

Adora’s brow scrunches. “What? What did I say?”

Her heart beats faster and faster. Under Catra’s fur, it feels warm. Too warm. When Adora’s dumb frown starts to shift towards

genuine concern, Catra's realizes she probably looks like she's panicking. She doesn't even know why.

Something about Adora's casual rejection of Glimmer feels...personal. Like if Adora can just dismiss Sparkles after all these years, nothing's stopping her from doing the same thing to Catra.

This whole time, Catra had thought she was different. Her and Adora had so much history; they'd shared beds and stories and tears and secrets and inside jokes. But Glimmer and Adora had shared an apartment for the last few years – even if Bow was around – so she probably felt the same way.

If DT had been a little more clumsy in describing Catra's feelings, would Adora still be saying the same thing? That she and *Catra* could never have feelings for each other? Adora just shines so bright. It's hard not to be blinded by that. Hard to not to feel the cold in her shadow.

"Hold up, Glimmer. I'm with you." Catra turns to follow her but Adora grabs her hand quickly.

"Wait, Cat. Tell me what's wrong." Adora pulls her hand until Catra's just a couple inches away from her. "Please."

Catra has to fight to not to scream what an idiot she is. Or worse, close her eyes and lean in closer. So many slumber parties, she woke up wrapped in Adora's arms and didn't give in to the urge to kiss those gorgeous lips. She's not about to cave now and ruin everything just cause they're in a stupid life or death situation.

Catra can hear Glimmer tugging at one of the doors with no success. She gives a huff and tries to pull away but Adora holds on.

"For real, Glimmer," Catra calls out. "Just slow down. It's not safe."

A phone light suddenly flashes right in Catra's eyes because apparently Glimmer's back to being a complete asshole.

“What do you care?” The light swivels down towards their grip on each other.

Catra takes a step back from Adora. “Cause I get it.”

“Get what?” Adora asks.

“Nothing,” Glimmer shoots back quickly. She gives Catra a look that definitely says ‘I’ll kill you if you open your mouth.’

Adora laughs nervously. “Are the two of you keeping a secret from me?”

Glimmer doesn’t take her eyes off of Catra.

“No, it’s just something stupid. It doesn’t matter,” Sparkles says with so much finality. Her eyes go back and forth between the two of them a couple more times, before she gives a wet-sounding laugh. “So fucking stupid. I’m going to find Scorpia.”

She takes off running quickly. Catra tries to follow but Adora grabs her again.

“Cat, come on. What’s up? You look up-”

“The *fuck?!”* Glimmer grumbles.

At first, Catra just thinks it’s just jealousy from Adora checking on her instead of following after Sparkles. And then they hear the signs of a struggle.

With a hell of a lot more caution, they check the rest of the rooms that they can get open in the basement. Adora doesn’t stop yelling Glimmer’s name the entire time, even though Catra keeps shushing her and reminding her that they’re also looking for Scorpia.

There’s no sign of either of them.

“Fuck,” Catra whispers to herself. Her claws are out, ready to strike.

But while Adora gets the creepy sense that they're definitely being watched, it's also starting to sink in that they're the only two left. It's sorta what she had hoped for at the beginning of this, but the reality is terrifying.

All Mermista left behind was a pool of blood. Who knows what the hell happened to Kyle in that fog. Bow got sucked into the floor right in front of them. Entrapta. Scorpia. DT. Adora's gonna be having nightmares about snakes for at least a few months. And now Glimmer, who's genuinely one of the scariest people Adora’s ever met, has been snatched.

They'd tried ignoring the game that someone was playing with them. Rationalizing it away. Planning to fight back. Plotting.

Now it was just the two of them and Adora was out of ideas. Waiting it out didn't seem to be an option. Whoever was doing this could easily pick Adora and Catra off by morning.

Adora goes to check her phone for how much longer they have. As soon as she turns it over and sees the 1% next to her battery, the device goes black.

“Shit, it died.”

“Duh. You were running around with the light on all night.”

Unlike upstairs, there's no place for Catra to light candles in the basement so Adora's left stumbling around in the dark as they head back towards the furthest wall.

“Do you really not have a phone, Cat?”

Catra begins poking at some wires that Adora can't really see.

“Dummy. You think if I had a phone, you wouldn't be the first person I'd call?”

“People don't call. They text. I'm gonna have to teach you phone etiquette when I get you one.”

“I don't need people being able to get in touch with me,” Catra grumbles.

“No, this number is exclusive to me,” Adora tells her. Even to her own ears, her voice sounds somewhere between desperate and possessive.

Being faced with her own mortality, Adora's starting to realize some things. Taking on too much responsibility for her family led her to this bizarre place. If she makes it out with the money, she wants to become a doctor at a clinic that works with at-risk kids, make sure that this was all worth it and benefits someone besides herself. Hell, maybe even come back to the Fright Zone and work there.

Most importantly, she's never letting Catra go again. What’s the point of living her dreams if she has to do it without the person who’s always mattered the most to her?

Wrapping her hands around Catra's forearm, Adora pulls her away from her task.

“Hey, I’m trying to get some godsdamn light down here so you can see, dum-”

Adora shuts her up by pressing their lips together. It’s awkward. Not at all how Adora had imagined it over the years, where she thought the world would freeze and butterflies would explode in her stomach and suddenly everything would fall perfectly into place.

Instead, *Catra* freezes and they’re stuck with their lips together in a way that reminds Adora of the awkward first kiss she had in 8th grade with Starla. It happened after a volleyball game when Starla pulled her into the equipment closet and Catra stumbled onto them and didn’t speak to Adora for a whole weekend.

Adora pulls back, her stomach plummeting. Everything does fall into place, just not in the way that she'd dreamed. Catra doesn't want her. All this time, Adora had been right – she was head over heels for Catra, something she could only allow herself to admit occasionally cause the knowledge of how it would never be returned was enough to break her in half.

She knew Catra liked girls. They'd confessed that to each other at 15 after stealing a couple beers from Catra's mom and getting tipsy up on the roof of her house. But Adora could never be the type of girl that Catra wanted, brave and reckless and cool.

Holy hell! What if Catra actually likes *Glimmer* and that's why they're always fighting whenever they're around each other? Honestly, Cat would be the type to pull her crush's pigtails.

"Oh my Gods," Catra whispers and Adora winces.

Her instinct is to run off and hide but she knows they can't split up right now because they need each other to survive. So she's forced to stand there while Catra starts laughing.

"How are we so bad at that?!" she asks incredulously as her giggles get squeaky in that way that always makes Adora swoon.

Except right now, it kinda makes Adora want to cry at how Catra's just rubbing salt in the wound.

"Come here, you dork," Catra softly says.

She doesn't give Adora time to move before her arms are wrapping around the blonde's neck and she's moving closer so that their bodies are fully touching in as many places as possible.

This feels a lot more right, a lot more *them.* But Adora's brain kinda doesn't know how to shift gears from the crushing rejection she just experienced. Her arms remain awkwardly at her sides as Catra leans down for another kiss.

Her lips are already slightly parted as they meet Adora's. She's a lot more tender and patient than Adora would have thought. Catra moves so gently, so out of character with how she jumps into everything like a force of nature. Her kiss is a hum against Adora's mouth. A flutter. A whisper.

And then Catra sighs dreamily and immediately bites into Adora's bottom lip using her fangs.

That's enough to jolt Adora into reality. This is really happening. Catra's kissing her (in Weaver's basement, which is pretty unfortunate but makes perfect sense in a weird way…) so she better make a fucking move finally.

Adora moves her hands to Catra's lower back, sliding them under the sweater that she had lent earlier. Her fingers ruffle the soft but slightly thicker fur at the base of Catra's spine. Catra arches up into the touch, stepping up on her tiptoes and coincidentally pushing her boobs further into Adora.

They're still not close enough, even when Catra slips her tongue into Adora's mouth and the hint of pain from her rough tongue makes the blonde feel weak in the knees. She pushes Catra against the wall and pins her there so Adora can take more control. They keep at it for a while, kisses growing just a little frantic as hands grip and clench and begin to get bold.

It's not perfect in the way that Adora had envisioned but it works for them and all their messiness and blurry lines. The dance they've done for years, to music only they can hear.

When Catra pulls back to take a deep breath, Adora dives into peppering kisses along her neck. She hits a spot right near Catra's collarbone and gets a lovely quiet moan in response.

"Wait," Catra says breathlessly. She has to push on Adora's shoulders to get her attention, so wrapped up in trying to get as much out of this temporary rift in reality as possible.

Adora gives her some space but has to keep her hands on Catra's hips to make sure she doesn't go too far. What if she's freaking out?

"Uhh," Catra stutters nervously. In the dark, Adora can just barely see her bright eyes casting downward. "This isn't some thing where you think you're gonna die and just want to make sure you've had your first kiss, right?"

For revenge, Adora spanks her on the ass. Catra squeaks in surprise and her tail swings around to tickle Adora's ear.

"No, listen. Shut up."

"So romantic," Catra says sarcastically.

"I don't know what the hell is going on around here. I don't know what's gonna happen to us. But I know it would be a huge mistake if I didn't tell you that I-"

After a few tense seconds, Catra prompts, "You what?"

Adora feels her chest tighten a little. This is somehow more frightening than actually just kissing Catra.

"I really did miss you. If we get out of here alive, I want us to talk more. I want us to be in each other's lives. I want to know everything and share everything like we used to."

"Me too," Catra tells her quietly. "I'll get a stupid phone. I'll learn how to send fucking calendar requests. I'll be, like, a semi-reliable person. The kind of person you deserve."

Adora doesn't realize she's crying until she hears how choked up her laugh sounds. "You're really making sacrifices for me there," she jokes.

"Yeah, well...I love you," Catra says in a low voice.

Adora tries to say it back. But in her excitement at hearing the words she's always dreamed of, she clumsily launches herself into a kiss so quickly that the force of it knocks Catra back against the wall behind them. Catra hisses a little.

"Sorry!"

"Shh!"

Another attempt at apologizing is thwarted by Catra slapping her hand over Adora's mouth while she turns to examine something.

Catra growls out, "Those idiots."

Adora tries to remain calm while Catra lets her arm go. With a few grunts and some strange clicking, Catra makes a triumphant little chirrup. And then Adora hears a switch flip and the lights return. It's so bright that it hurts and Adora has to squint to adjust after hours of wandering around in the dark.

"We were so focused on looking at all the many fucked up wires that we didn't see this damn thing was a decoy. The actual breaker was hidden *behind* it. I swear, if we inherit this house, I'm burning it to the ground for being so fucking annoying."

"You're a genius," Adora barely gets out before pulling her in for another long kiss.

Under her hands, Catra's ears swivel. A few seconds later, Adora hears it too. There's rustling in the walls. Next to them, something is moving around. It starts as a quiet squirming but soon grows into a louder sound that's closer to banging.

The two of them jump apart in alarm.

"That better be rats," Catra says, narrowing her eyes at the wall.

The banging gets more insistent until it cuts off with a high-pitched shriek.

“Finally!” a voice screams. “I'm in here fighting for my life and you're *making out?!”*

“Glimmer?!” Adora yells back at her, relieved and still pretty freaked out.

There’s a bigger thump that nearly rattles the wall.

“Scorpia’s here too,” Glimmer tells them. “Now, can you stop rubbing your stupid love in our faces and come untie us? Fucking selfish fuckers.”

“How the hell did you even get in there?” Catra asks.

“Not the important question! Move your asses!”

Catra rolls her eyes as she begins to move around the basement, looking for any clues on how to sneak into yet another creepy crawlspace.

“Glim, any idea how we're supposed to get in there?” Adora tries.

“Oh, for fuck’s sake!”

There's more rustling. Then more. Then it kinda sounds like Glimmer and Scorpia are fighting.

“Everything okay in there?”

Glimmer sounds muffled, as if there's something in her mouth, when she yells back, “No! My fate is in the hands of the most useless-” She cuts off with a loud grunt.

“Hooray!” Scorpia shouts. “Good job, little buddy!”

Voice hard as stone, Glimmer shoots back, “Don't fucking ever call me that. Tell these two clowns how to find us. *Now.”*

Scorpia’s sense of direction is surprisingly shit. She recites a convoluted map that’s got so many detours and small random crap to stop and look at that Catra eventually gives up and slices

through the drywall, claiming at least it's much easier than dealing with the wooden slats on the top floors. There's a small chip where Glimmer was able to peek out and spy on them once the lights went back on. Catra digs her claws in a little and it crumbles away like a sandcastle. Adora helps as best as she can, using pure strength to rip pieces of the weak old wall away after Catra further loosens them for her.

"Weaver might not get you tonight but that asbestos is slowly gonna creep up on you over the years," Glimmer warns with a smirk when Catra's cleared away enough debris to see them.

The passageway they're stuck in is so narrow that it's a wonder it fit Scorpia at all. They're both on their butts, ankles bound and wrists tied behind their backs with rope. Bandanas hang around their necks. They look completely exhausted and mussed, though Scorpia's eyes are beaming at Catra for saving them.

"They couldn't keep a muzzle on you, Sparkles?" she asks, nodding at the cloth under Glimmer's chin.

"You think this is my first experience working my way out of a gag?" Glimmer replies.

Adora could be mistaken but Catra almost laughs. With a sigh, she reaches for Glimmer first while Adora tries to figure out how they're going to drag Scorpia out of a hole that's only big enough for even Glimmer to barely crawl out of.

Catra cuts through the ropes easily so that Glimmer's able to scramble out of the way and make room for Scorpia. It takes a lot of awkward ramming – and a lot of Catra drooling in Adora's general direction as she tries to basically punch her way out of the situation – but they're able to help get Scorpia free after several long minutes.

They're too busy exchanging relieved hugs to notice anyone's snuck up on them. Not until the gun cocks.

It’s not a sound that Catra’s heard outside of movies honestly. The danger in her life has always been more... mystical. Not as human and simple as an asshole with a gun.

They all have their backs to the person, standing awkwardly in a half-circle as someone gets the drop on them. Even if they’d seen them coming, Scorpia and Glimmer clearly aren’t at 100%. And Catra would do anything to keep Adora safe, even if she’s still kinda reeling from the fact that they *kissed(!)*.

So she freezes, reminds herself not to make any sudden moves. Don’t freak the person out. If she sees an opening, she’s going for it but only if Adora’s out of the line of fire.

“Ugh,” a familiar voice groans. Catra’s sure she must be hallucinating from the stress now. “Do you think this is a stick-up? Who would rob you broke bitches?”

Catra spins around on her heel quickly and her breath catches. There’s Mermista, standing before her. Alive and well and not looking like she’s suffered from a fatal loss of blood. She’s a little dusty and there are cobwebs in her hair. But her face is as blase as ever. Her left hand is cocked on her hip and in her right is one of Weaver’s antique gold pistols, the barrel long, thin, and deadly-looking. It points lazily at the floor.

“Gods, I wish I had a camera,” Catra murmurs.

The edge of Mermista’s lip turns up slightly. “I’m really pulling this look off, right?

“Mermista!” Scorpia screams with joy. “Are you okay?”

“Okay?!” she repeats and suddenly her whole demeanor changes. Eyes blazing wildly, she lunges towards Scorpia. Her face nearly splits in half from how wide she’s smiling. “This is the best night of my life! Come on!”

Mermista raises the gun and takes off running down the hall towards the stairs. They should probably stay away from the gun-

toting weirdo who was already just a little unhinged *before* someone maybe tried to kill her. But morbid curiosity drives Catra's need to see how this plays out. She's only half-sure that she maybe should also try to keep Mermista safe.

"I *think* she's gonna confront whoever's up to all this. I'll follow her. You all stay down here and hide," Catra tells the others.

"No way. I'm taking my chances with Mermista," Glimmer replies.

"She always roots for the villains in movies," Adora whispers. "I'm with you all the way to the end, Cat."

Scorpia places a pincer on her shoulder. "Me too, Wildcat! You saved me and Glimmer. The code of honor says we are forever in your debt."

"I'd like the record to reflect that I have no honor," Glimmer asserts. "I'm just using you as a shield. If you and I get out of this, we have a different score to settle."

Catra chuckles at the gall of this little monster. With a nod towards Adora, she asks, "Not gonna bow out gracefully?"

"This night has proven that literally anything can happen," Glimmer says defiantly.

Scorpia looks to Adora. "Do you know what they're talking about?"

"Almost never," Adora admits with a sigh. "Let's follow your friend before she hurts someone."

Mermista's waiting at the top of the stairs, trying to creep around in the shadows, when they get there.

"Took you long enough! Let's go!"

With her free hand, Mermista tugs Catra down the hall. They stick close to the walls while Mermista goes into full spy mode, aiming

the gun in front of her while she does a weird half-squat-jog from doorway to doorway.

Behind them, Scorpia, Adora, and Glimmer move completely normally, if maybe a little robotically. Apparently that's their version of stealth. Catra has to pause to laugh three times.

Mermista leads them to the library, even though Scorpia tries to protest.

"Maybe we should find another hiding place," she suggests.

"No, this is the perfect spot for the final act," Mermista argues.

"Final act?" Adora repeats, looking horrified.

"Merms, that's a little dark. Even for you," Catra says.

"No, seriously, there's some fishy stuff happening in the nook over there," Scorpia tries to tell them.

Mermista pulls out the sliding door that's recessed into the library wall and closes it. She locks it for good measure.

"Are there more guns?" Glimmer asks.

Catra's forced to pray that there are not. The last thing any of them needs is for that hothead to be *armed.* Particularly, after seeing her and Adora kiss.

Mermista ignores her to cut through the library and head over to the door just off the corner of that reading area that no one's ever in. She grabs a chair and wedges it under the doorknob.

Adora wipes her hand nervously on her jeans. "Okay, would any of you like to explain what's going on? Or where you've been?"

Mermista continues her sweep of the room before coming back and stopping before them. She shoves the gun in her waistband before clearing her throat dramatically.

“Well, I’d suggest you take a seat. It’s an absolute fucking yarn.”

Reluctantly, they sit themselves on the old chestnut-colored leather couches in the center of the room. Mermista remains standing.

“There’s a simple explanation,” she says, really drawing it out. And is she doing a hint of an accent? “And there’s the much more complicated one.”

“Everyone’s disappearing and you’re out here ripping off Mer-Mysteries?” Catra asks.

“On the contrary!” Mermista dramatically screams, pointing at her. “This is so much more obvious than a Mer-Mystery. This is like that kiddie book series they turned into a Saturday morning cartoon. I cracked it as soon as you all went to investigate that fake break-in.”

Adora’s eyes shoot to Catra as if she has any fucking clue what’s happening here. Finding nothing, the blonde looks back at Mermista. “But you still let yourself get kidnapped?”

“Ha!” Mermista gives a fake theater laugh. “I *faked* my own abduction to make our attacker *think* I was out of the picture. Now, stop interrupting.”

She crosses her arms behind her back and begins slowly pacing to and fro in front of them. “The simple explanation – the one someone *wants* you to believe is that Weaver's creepy house is completely booby-trapped. And that, plus the dozens of ghosts, are what's after us.”

Mermista pauses to look them each in the eye, like she expects shock or gasps.

She doesn't resume talking for several seconds so Catra throws her a bone so they can get this over with. “Is that not true?”

“True?” Mermista repeats, scratching her chin. “It *could* be true. And yet! That doesn't explain the sabotaged electricity. Or the precise timing of Lonnie and Entrapta's disappearances-”

“Are they okay, by the way?” Adora tries to interrupt.

“Shh! I'm monologuing!” She begins pacing again. “The ropes on Glimmer and Scorpia. Ghosts don't need ropes.”

“Yeah, I was definitely in a fist fight with a *person*, not a poltergeist,” Glimmer interjects. “That’s who tied me up and dragged me into the wall where Scorpia was.”

“Exactly!” Mermista shouts, spinning in her direction. “The more complicated explanation is that someone’s been masterminding this whole thing. Th-”

Catra mumbles, talking right over Mermista, “That’s not that complicated. I think we kinda assumed that’s what was happening, like, several hours ago.”

“-ey manipulated Hordak somehow to get us all here. Have been blending in to make us think they’re one of us. Using the house’s general creepy vibe to scare everyone and make them act dumb. They’ve even got secret cameras set up to watch us. They grabbed Scorpia as soon as she discovered those. Figured out all the old hiding places and passageways to sneak around unseen and set traps. I’ve been dodging them all night to spy.”

Adora cuts her eyes towards Scorpia, who just looks fully engrossed in Mermista’s storytelling. Glimmer, however, has already lost patience for this completely. Her hands are pulling at her hair in frustration.

Mermista continues on, unbothered. “It had to be some person or *persons* who had unlimited access to this place. Either the technical savvy to fuck with the security system, your car app, our phones. Or the ability to convince someone into doing so.”

Scorpia literally gasps. “Is it me? Have I been sleep-walking?”

Catra puts her head in her hands. “No, you big goober, it’s Entrapta. Of course it is. She’s probably running some experiment on fear vs money as a motivator.”

Mermista drops the self-serious facade for a second. “Nah, it wasn’t Entrapta. She figured her way out of her trap and took off hours ago. Shorted out the gate or something.”

“Wait! We can leave?!” Glimmer interrupts. “I’m getting the fuck out of here.”

“Uggghhh, you’re gonna miss the best part though,” Mermista tells her with a groan.

Glimmer turns to Adora but her roommate shows no sign of wanting to escape as she crosses her arms and relaxes further into the couch. Glimmer just huffs and does the same.

“Anyway,” Mermista resumes her ridiculous detective stance. “The person had to be strong enough to overpower Scorpia.”

“Oh, I was just drugged,” Scorpia points out.

“Smart enough to think they could outwit me.”

“I once saw a soda dispenser outwit you,” Catra adds, thinking of the time Mermista took her to the movies and ended up punching the drink machine cause it was too ‘futuristic’ and she couldn't figure out how to get a non-flavored coke.

“And stealthy enough to run circles around Kitty.”

“Hey, they’re in the fucking walls. It’s basically cheating.”

“But what’s the point of all of this?” Adora asks. “Was the inheritance just a lie?”

Mermista raises her right index finger in the air as if she’s about to make an amazing revelation. Instead, she bites bottom lip and says, “Yeah, that I actually don’t know about.”

Everyone nearly screams. All of that fucking talking just to say nothing of consequence.

Really, Catra's mostly confused by one big thing. "You always carry that much blood around on you?"

Glimmer heaves a frustrated groan. "Does this house make everyone lose their mind eventually? Mermista, *just tell us who is doing this."*

She opens her mouth to reply just as the library door unlocks with a loud click. They all immediately leap to their feet as Mermista dives for the door. Catra thinks she's going to draw the gun and defend them but Catra soon realizes she's a naive fool.

"Godsdamnit, Kyle! You are *not* stealing my moment," Mermista yells out, struggling to keep the door closed.

A sound thuds between Catra's ears that she's pretty sure is her brain exploding. "Wait. It's *Kyle?!?!"*

Glimmer and Adora look at her blankly cause clearly he didn't leave much of an impression on them. Scorpia seems appropriately shocked and confused.

Kyle? Impish, clumsy, simpering Kyle?

Catra's known him for years and not once considered that he'd have something like this in him. Kyle rescued bugs from the house so Weaver wouldn't make Scorpia squash them and made really ugly beaded jewelry in his free time.

Though Weaver did once predict that in 15 years, he'd either be very successful or have warrants out for his arrest in several states. He had a mixture of sycophancy and incompetence only found in Fortune 500 CEOs and doomsday cultists, she claimed.

"Not Kyle," Scorpia mutters to herself. "We-we're *friends.* I helped him and Rogelio move in together. I was the only person from work who came to their barbecue in August."

Mermista grunts as a larger force tries to wrench the door open and she has to get low to the ground to use her weight to keep her grip.

Fuck. Rogelio, Weaver's driver, is the only one big and strong enough, plus sympathetic to Kyle, to use that much force.

"You never saw the person who dropped you off here, right?" Catra asks Adora.

"Not directly. They had gloves and a hat and the divider was super dark."

"Yes, it's Kyle!" Mermista shouts, right as she intentionally lets the door go.

She leaps back into the center of the room so that the focus is still fully on her as they enter.

Rogelio comes in first, scowling at Mermista. His large frame takes up practically the entire doorway. Instead of his driver's suit, he's dressed in all black, tight longsleeve shirt, jeans, and leather gloves. He's not wearing shoes and Catra nearly slaps herself for not looking more closely around the house for footprints as they were running around like idiots.

He moves to the side and balls his hands into fists, trying to intimidate them. Kyle walks in after him, already red-faced and annoyed, not at all the villain that Catra was expecting.

Kyle's still dressed in his uniform, the three-piece suit that fits him poorly, and is decidedly *not* torn apart by wolves.

His face immediately falls. "You couldn't let me have this one thing, Mermista? I spent weeks on this and you steal my thunder. Unbelievable."

"Kyle, buddy," Scorpia calls out, bottom lip trembling and eyes filling with tears. "Why? Why would you do this to us?"

He takes a couple menacing steps closer to her, which is ridiculous because Scorpia towers over him.

“Why?” he repeats. He attempts a maniacal laugh but his voice cracks halfway through. “Because you’re all toilet people! Do you even notice how badly you treat me?”

“But we’ve always been pals!” Scorpia says. She does look genuinely hurt to be lumped in with the rest of those assholes.

“You just stand there when Weaver berates me!”

That takes some of the fight out of Scorpia. Eyes casting towards the floor with guilt, she shrinks into herself. Kyle turns to Catra next.

“You convinced someone to put up a Kyle Purcell Memorial Highway sign on the route I take home everyday!”

“I thought you’d appreciate the tribute,” Catra replies, trying not to laugh at her own dumb prank. It was like 3 years ago. That was plenty of time to recover.

“Well, I’ve never done anything to you,” Glimmer points out.

“Yeah, we don’t even know you,” Adora chimes in.

Catra winces immediately. The dummy’s kinda accidentally proving Kyle’s whole point.

“Glimmer, you tried to get me fired when you were an apprentice because I dropped a case of carrier oil and some of it splashed on your shirt,” Kyle reminds her.

“Well, I probably didn’t mean it! I make empty threats all the time. I can’t help it — I’m a Sagittarius.”

He points at Adora next. “You don’t know me? I started working here a year after you did. We were in the same 6th grade class.

We did little league together. I was the waterboy when you played basketball in high school."

Adora covers her mouth with her fist, face going all red from embarrassment. "I am *so* so sorry…"

"Kyle!" he finishes for her.

Catra's shoulders shake with silent laughter. "To be fair, we really only ever had eyes for each other."

Adora turns to give her a soft look, smiling brilliantly. Catra reaches up and teases a light touch across her jaw.

"No one cares about your gross true love!" Kyle whines. "You don't get to be rude to people just cause you're obsessed with each other."

Glimmer and Scorpia grumble their agreement. Adora lowers her head and apologizes again.

"What about Bow?" Glimmer asks. "Unless he secretly went to camp with you or some bullshit, he's never even met you before."

"Well, I did actually need someone to round out the number. 10's so much better than 9. Lonnie was always kind of a jerk but she's like that to everyone. You saw how DT treats me. Half the time, Entrapta was helping everyone prank me. But once I got her to agree to help me with some tiny projects, I had to get rid of her too before she figured out they were all connected and that tonight was a hoax."

"Hoax? You bought a whole pit of snakes and poisoned DT," Glimmer argues.

"They were king snakes that I *borrowed* from a friend who's a collector. DT is fine. You maniacs are the ones who abandoned them."

"Ha! Called it!" Adora yells.

“Most importantly, I solved this whole thing,” Mermista points out. “I’m a better detective than Inspector Carp.”

Kyle whines, “This is my revenge and you’re ruining it by still being dicks!”

Rogelio grunts sympathetically. He comes over and gently cradles Kyle to his body, petting his hair and grunting that the rest of them should be ashamed of themselves.

“You’re right,” Scorpia says, fully crying now. “I was such a bad friend. I didn’t even realize i-“

Catra jumps to her feet, completely fucking over this. “So there’s no money?”

“Of course not!” Kyle answers. “I don’t think there ever was. Weaver barely paid us most weeks. I just bribed Hordak to say that by giving him some secret files of Weaver’s that he wanted.”

Everyone deflates. With a scowl, Mermista goes to stand over near the window. Glimmer looks like she’ll definitely be going home to put a hex on Kyle’s whole lineage.

Catra moves around the back of the couch, prowling back and forth. They spent a whole night in this house, being scared out of their fucking minds for nothing. No money, no nest egg to help her with grad school. It was just another failure in a long line of them, busting her ass for Weaver with nothing to show for it.

As she turns to repeat her steps, a hand reaches out and grabs her. Catra startles, looking to the couch where Adora’s smiling sadly at her. She looks disappointed too but...hopeful maybe?

Catra feels her heart pick up. Well, she didn’t exactly get *nothing* out of the night. Adora had kissed her. Had heard Catra say she loved her and hadn’t run away screaming. They probably need to figure out what that means for them but everything was finally out in the open. That was a good start.

Adora gently kisses Catra's palm before releasing her hand. She turns back to Kyle with a sigh. "This whole plan is so bonkers. So intense! Mermista had to fake her own attack to stay safe."

"Yeah, that's crazy, Mermista. This was just a prank," Kyle says. "You didn't really have to go that far."

Mermista scoffs. "Please. I worked with Weaver. Do you know how many times I've had to fake my own death to get out of some shit?"

Catra finally gathers herself. She walks slowly over to their tormentor. "Well, this is the most that I've ever respected you, Kyle. You should know that I'll have my payback though."

Glimmer points out, "So you've learned literally nothing about how to treat people or the cycle of violence."

Catra ignores that. "Okay, seems like we're done here. I'm calling the cops now. Unless you're looking to be a co-defendent or a witness for the prosecution, I'd suggest you highttail it the fuck out of here."

"Cops?!" Kyle squeaks. "It was just a joke!"

"Yeah, unlawful imprisonment is hilarious, Kyle," Mermista bites back.

"Ro, release the traps," he hisses before rushing out, Rogelio trailing along behind him.

Mermista slinks silently out of the room. She's probably got 4 other scams running simultaneously that she needs to go check on.

There's a few loud mechanical sounds coming from the bowels of the house. Taking Adora's hand, Catra heads back out into the foyer to prepare for whatever remaining shenanigans are bound to come. Kyle left the front door wide open and over the fog, Catra can just barely see the sun rising over the horizon.

“Are you okay?” she asks Adora.

The blonde shrugs, eyes wide. “I think I’m still in shock. Big night.” She nods absently. “Big night,” she repeats to herself.

Catra puts her arms around Adora’s waist just in case she’s going to faint or something.

Eventually, she hears Glimmer and Scorpia join them. Scorpia’s still worrying over being a bad friend to Kyle, which Sparkles clearly could not be less interested about.

“Maybe I’ll send him a nice gift basket. Or-or an edible arrangement?”

“Yeah, I don’t know the etiquette for thanking your kidnapper,” Glimmer says, sounding droll and exhausted. “Can we get the fuck out of here now? Bow!”

“Uh...coming?” someone answers.

Like they’ve been summoned, DT, Lonnie, and Bow come running up from the basement, all completely terrified.

Catra nods at Lonnie. “What got you?”

She shrugs, regaining some of her cool. “Picked up a creepy doll and accidentally opened a giant pit. Honestly, that's not even the first time that's happened to me here.”

“What’s going on?” Bow asks. “Are we still in danger?”

“No, everyone learned a very important after-school special lesson about treating others with respect and I’m never going out on Halloween again,” Glimmer says. She begins pushing him towards the door.

“Ta ta, darlings,” DT smirks with a little wave. “I’ll just be waiting here.”

Catra holds up her hand to count off on her fingers. “There’s no money. Hordak’s not coming back. Kyle owned us all.”

DT doesn’t even break their stride, continuing right out the door. “Well, I’ll just be hitting the road then. Scorpia, would you be a dear and give me a ride home?”

“Yes! I would *love* to make sure you all make it home safely. Can’t be too careful, you know?” She follows the rest of them out. “All aboard, the SS Friendship!”

Lonnie shakes her head, taking up the rear. “Glad you two disasters finally figured out what the rest of us realized in 7th grade,” she tosses over her shoulder to Catra and Adora, arms still wrapped around each other. “Congrats.”

Catra makes sure to close and lock the door behind them. Scorpia will be back probably, since she lives there and everything, but there’s been more than enough surprises for the night. She leans back against the door to find Adora looking at her inquisitively.

“Are you really gonna call the cops?”

“Hell no. Fuck 12. Kyle will be held accountable by his community.”

“Can you, Lonnie, and Mermista maybe just let this one go? You pranked him. He pranked you. Everyone’s even.”

True. Except, Kyle’s prank cost Catra her chance at finally cracking Weaver’s secrets. Entrapta’s probably back in her nerd hole now. Catra had been convinced that Weaver was hoarding cash in the house but never had an opportunity to track any of it down. Entrapta had been the one to notice those random hot spots in the walls, places where she was convinced that no pipes or electricity should be yet were somehow much warmer than anything else around them.

Without Entrapta, Catra had no way to hunt them all down or crack whatever puzzles Weaver undoubtedly left behind to guard

her treasures. It felt like days of work after spending more than 24 hours straight awake and running on fumes and adrenaline.

Weaver owed them — owed *Catra* especially — from years of ripping them off. But fine. She'd just have to figure out another way.

"There's still one thing that's bothering me," Adora says.

"Just one? *Really??"*

"How'd Kyle know to use a fake party invite to lure me and my friends here?"

"Sparkles was asking for an in to that little rave for *weeks* on TikTok. Honestly, she was practically begging to be scammed."

Adora makes an incredulous face. "...You know what TikTok is but not how to text?"

"Why do you try to make me sound so ancient and uncool?"

"It comes so easy. Ready to head home?" Adora asks as Catra slumps against the door. All she can do is nod. "Okay. Can I...can I come over and stay with you?"

"Sleepover?" Catra responds automatically. "That dumb costume stays here though."

"Do you think we'll ever find out if that's Mermista's actual blood on your jacket?"

Catra sighs. "So not only am I *not* rich, I'm out of the cost of a new jacket? Why do bad things happen to me? I'm so wonderful."

"Should I remind you of the memorial highway?"

"You know the weirdest part? The county's never taken down the sign. Like, where do my tax dollars go?"

“You don't pay taxes cause everything about this job is highly illegal,” Adora reminds her with a smirk.

“Oh, right. So sleepover?”

“I thought we established that.”

“You never agreed,” Catra says casually. Deep down, she's hoping maybe Adora's lack of response was due to wanting a bit more than their usual arrangement.

“I was the one who proposed it.”

“Fair point.”

Adora awkwardly clears her throat, as a blush crawls up her cheeks. “Actually, I was wondering-no pressure by the way, I mean. You don't have to decide right this second. Just if...well, if it could be a little. Hm, *different?”*

Curiosity piqued, Catra raises an eyebrow. “Different how?”

“Well, maybe let's not tell your mom I'm there. And let's lock the door. And maybe we don't spend the whole time just sleeping.” Adora's smile is somehow both shy and too confident that Catra will say yes.

“Like what? Watching movies?” Catra asks, pretending to play dumb.

Adora squints her eyes slightly. “No. Like, uh…”

“Telling stories about boys?”

“Not unless I *really* misread some signals. What I was thinking was we could-” Adora’s interrupted by the growling of her own stomach. “Well, first, we should get some food. I feel like I haven’t eaten in forever.”

That reminds Catra of the abandoned candy bar she never got to finish. She pulls the remainder, still carefully wrapped, from her pocket. It's honestly just to distract from how going back and forth with Adora, ribbing each other and talking way too fast, still gives her that unsettling feeling of being completely settled and safe. The candy's shockingly not melted after all this running around.

"Ooh, you still have some left?" Adora asks as Catra breaks off a square of chocolate and pops it into her mouth. "Can I have a piece?"

"No, you ate yours, greedy. This one's mine."

"But I gave it to you," Adora whines.

"Exactly."

"Just one piece, Cat." Adora pouts, sticking out her bottom lip and making doe eyes.

Catra stares her down so she won't miss a second of Adora's reaction. She breaks off another square and places it in her own mouth, gripping the end right between her teeth. Adora gives an exaggerated frown that almost makes Catra break and laugh.

Instead, she slowly moves closer, stepping away from the door. Adora's face goes from disappointed to confused as Catra closes the distance between them. When they're within arms reach of each other, Adora mostly just freezes as she waits for the next move. Catra tilts her head and leans in. She won't admit to herself how relieved she is when Adora does the same, coming up to meet her halfway.

Their lips brush lightly and Catra practically eats up the way Adora's breath hitches before she reaches for Catra's waist to hold her closer.

Adora takes a soft bite of the candy, pulling her mouth away quickly as if Catra will try to renege and steal it back. Yet, her

hands continue drifting around Catra's hips until they're intertwined and locked behind her back.

"Can I have another piece?" Adora whispers, smirking like she thinks she just said the sexiest come-on.

"Stop being cute and move your asses!" Mermista yells, suddenly right next to them.

They both spring apart, Adora nearly falling backward into the wall behind her. Catra's heart is racing – not that it was going exactly slow before when she felt Adora's lips – and her fur rises all over.

Mermista moves forward before they can respond. Her energy's all frantic and sure and it's both thrilling and frightening when she's like this. Mermista thrusts an old, weathered piece of leather luggage into Catra's hands. The thing probably used to be white but it's discolored now, peeling at the edges, and so heavy that Catra almost drops it immediately.

"Come on," Mermista says quickly. "I'm not leaving without my inheritance."

"There isn't an inheritance," Adora replies.

"The hell there isn't. There's money all over this place. I'm grabbing everything I can hold."

She takes off again without another word. Catra throws the bag onto the floor. It's barely bigger than a modern carry-on but it feels like it weighs the size of a large toddler. Adora eyes the bag warily as Catra bends down to peek inside.

She nearly jumps back in shock again when it's open.

Mermista's stuffed this bag full of reams of cash – dozens of thick stacks of $20 and $50 bills, along with gold coins, some heavy intricate vases, and unbelievably what looks like a fucking diamond-crusted tiara.

Mermista pops her head back out into the room. “What the fuck are you waiting for? You want to pay for grad school or not?”

“This feels...wrong?” Adora tries.

“What a boring concept,” Mermista says.

“We’re stealing!”

“Do you know how much Weaver shorted us over the years? I’m getting what I’m owed.”

Adora turns to Catra, clearly conflicted. If she’s looking for a moral compass, the battle’s already lost.

“Weaver always did tell me that she supported your dreams,” Catra says. It’s not exactly a lie, just sorta stretching the truth a bit. Mostly the old lady would get tipsy and talk about how much better Adora was than the two of them.

“Great, come help me loot this place,” Mermista announces, before rushing off again.

“Be careful!” Adora shouts after her. That’s smart. This fucking house has been vaguely trying to harm them for hours.

They’re working against a deadline, in Catra’s mind at least. Just in case Hordak decides to pop back in and rob the place himself. Or, you know, Scorpia comes back all judgy. Catra’s able to convince Mermista to leave some things behind for the big lug, for all her pain and suffering too.

Mermista leads them through, uncovering more and more hidden treasures. In the attic, the floorboards, behind cabinets. She only wants the biggest shit and Catra has to agree.

“Adora, think you can lift this grandfather clock?” Merms asks, already dragging two full trunks behind herself.

“You’re vastly overestimating the amount of space in your Honda,” Adora replies.

As Mermista ducks out, Catra goes back to finding rope to strap their much more reasonable finds to her motorcycle.

“Think we got everything?” Adora calls out.

Catra meets her in the foyer. Adora looks nervous. Well, maybe, hesitant is more honest.

“Yeah, we’re good to go,” Catra answers.

“Are you really not coming back?”

“There’s not anything here for me. Good riddance, honestly.”

Adora nods slowly. “I know it wasn’t always great. But I guess. I, uh, kinda liked being here. Tonight with you? Is that weird?”

“Well, we thought we were fighting for our lives. But, uh, yeah. I liked being here with you too. You were the only thing that ever made this place feel not so fucking awful.”

Catra goes to lead them both out but Adora stops her with a gentle hand on her wrist. It’s a casual touch but Adora’s eyes are sweet and so moved as she pulls Catra into a kiss.

When they part, Catra laughs to herself quietly. “Weaver must be rolling in her grave.”

Adora takes the rope and heads out with the bags. Catra lingers in the doorway to give the place one last look. Adora’s right – she can keep the good memories and work to let the rest go.

As she turns to leave, Catra catches something out of the corner of her eye. It almost looks like a pale woman, dressed in a thin pink frock with branches in her hair.

“You’ll be back,” she whispers though her mouth doesn’t move.

A breeze drifts through, chilling Catra and ruffling her fur. She looks back to make sure this isn't another trick.

But there's nothing there. No woman. Nothing. Catra rubs her eyes, already convincing herself she made it up.

From the window upstairs, she watches them head out. That one, Mermista, was interesting to have around. Funny in her own way.

The other two. It was nice to have them in the house. They were sweet to each other. She tried talking to them a few times over the years but they never seemed to let themselves hear her.

Scorpia will be sad, all alone. That just won't do. She's so nice, so giving and cheerful. When the group began disappearing into the house, Perfuma thought maybe Scorpia was trying to keep them all there. Build a family to keep her company. But no, it was just a boring game.

Well, that's alright. Perfuma will just have to find a way to get them all back there.

Especially Catra.

Adora checks the mail when she comes in, mostly because she knows that Catra's probably already home and breezed right by the mailbox. Catra hasn't once checked it. They never get much of anything besides junk anyway but Catra still refuses to give out their address.

"Just in case," she says, and then she looks at Adora in this way that she probably thinks screams 'mystery' but really signifies that she's full of shit.

Technically, Catra doesn't actually live with Adora, because moving in together after only 2 months of officially dating would be ridiculous. And yet, everything Catra owns suddenly appeared there in the apartment 3 weeks into this relationship, she paid ¼

of the rent last month (in cash, for reasons she refuses to explain to Bow), and Glimmer's added her to the chore wheel, suspiciously to only do the chores that Glimmer herself hates. So really, what's more ridiculous is that Catra just won't tell the post office and her mother about her updated living situation.

Even though Adora's cut down on working nights and reduced her temp hours a bit, she still comes in exhausted. She likes the routine of having a place to be during the day and being useful but she's not sure how much longer she can keep up doing this while studying so intensely for the MCATs. When she comes into the apartment, she drops the mail on the coffee table in the living room and flops down onto the couch between Catra, who's reading a book for one of her pre-req classes, and Glimmer, who's pretending that she's watching TV alone.

"Long day?" Glimmer asks.

"Data entry is so boring. I think I fell asleep with my eyes open for a full 30 minutes and now they're super dry," Adora whines.

She looks to Glimmer for support but all she gets is an unimpressed frown. Turning to Catra next, she gets an absent pat on the thigh. Adora's still not 100% clear on how to navigate the remaining tension between the two of them. Catra claims they have a 'gentlewoman's agreement' to keep the peace. Most of the time, it's perfectly fine. It's just in moments like this, Adora's not sure which of her best friends she should go to first, especially now that one of them is her girlfriend.

Bow prevents further indecision by bursting into the apartment with a smile and 2 bags of noodles. While they eat, Adora joins him on the other couch and he graciously listens to her complain about her dull job while Catra and Glimmer take turns making fun of her for just not quitting.

"Gods forbid you break your deep and life-affirming commitment to a company that doesn't offer health insurance or a living wage," Glimmer sarcastically points out.

“I don’t think you have any particular allegiance to Professionals Staffing, Inc,” Catra says.

“It’s the principle. I’m not a quitter.”

Catra and Glimmer share a look and roll their eyes in tandem. Actually, maybe it’s better when they aren’t learning to be friends. Less people to gang up on Adora with logic.

Towards the end of the meal, Catra slinks into her and Adora’s room and returns with a very old $20 bill to repay Bow for half of dinner. This time, he doesn’t even bother to argue that it’s his treat or ask where she keeps getting these bills that are probably out of circulation. He just smiles and thanks her and suggests a gameshow for the 4 of them to watch together until it’s time for Adora to start her pre-bed studying.

Bow probably has some idea of what happened at Weaver’s place. Or enough to stop poking around. After Scorpia essentially took over ownership – though she still calls it the ‘Weaver place’ – she knocked down a few walls to let in more light and stumbled upon even more cash stashed away. She was generous enough to share it with all the folks who had put up with that night of hell, including Bow and Glimmer; there was a larger pot for the folks who had worked for Weaver – Lonnie, Rogelio, even Kyle.

“Oh, no thank you,” Entrapta supposedly told her. “I already embezzled more than my fair share straight out of Weaver’s bank accounts.”

Adora and Catra politely declined, to Glimmer's intense and loud disbelief. They had more than enough money. Scorpia deserved to hang on to more for all the time she put in working there.

Mermista had joked that she was opening her own detective agency. At least, Catra said she *hoped* that was a joke because Mermista was threatening to hire the rest of the crew to help her out.

“All those goons together could only end in a city-wide crime spree,” Catra had warned. “Shit. Do you think it’s too late for us to join?”

Thankfully, Catra kept her focus on school and their lives were nice and simple and largely drama-free. Even Glimmer had chilled out a bit. According to her, Bow’s willingness to sacrifice himself that night made her see him in a different light. They weren’t dating yet but Glimmer said she was allowing herself more time to “review her options.”

As Bow starts clearing the trash from dinner, he notices the mail on the table. He picks it up to take it with him to the kitchen and add it to the recycling.

“Oh, wait,” he says, pausing. “This one’s actual mail. It’s for you, Adora.”

He hands over a manila envelope. It’s addressed to Adora but there’s no return address, no stamp.

“That’s fucking bizarre,” Catra comments, leaning over across the armrest.

“Hey, if you don’t get mail here, you don’t have the right to read mine,” Adora says.

“Glimmer,” is all Catra says and then their roommate reaches over and snatches the letter out of Adora’s hand.

“Maybe you have a secret admirer,” Glimmer jokes. She rips open the envelope with no concern or caution for what’s inside.

Glimmer pulls out a piece of yellow lined notebook paper. She makes a confused face before handing it over to Adora.

There’s a message hand-written on the paper, in a shaky, hard-to-read cursive that looks like it was done by an elderly toddler.

"The news of my demise has been greatly exaggerated. I shall be seeing you soon to reclaim what's mine."

- W

Chapter End Notes

did i write this whole thing just so mermista could solve a mer-mystery? (yes)



credit to nbc22 for dark perfuma and to randoofrandos for perfuma being dryad-esque.

thanks again for reading!! 🖤 🖤 hopefully, i'll be back with fluffy smut soon!

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